Uppsala University

Master's Thesis

Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate

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April 12, 2026

1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Brief Overview

Through this thesis project, I apply transformative game design theory and best practices to create a new competitive debating format. This research employs Research through Design (RtD) methodology to develop and playtest an alternative debate format that addresses what I believe to be systematic problems in widely-used formats, particularly World Schools and British Parliamentary debate.

Structurally, I define how the major debate rulesets (called formats) are already games, are transformative and are roleplaying. Then I argue that there are issues with them that prevent them from being as positively transformative as they should be, and use transformative role-playing game design theory to point how they ought to change to address said issues. In the methods section I explain how I go about designing and testing a new debate format that should address these issues. Based on the same theory I defend my design and describe how it evolved in light of playtesting.

1.2 Motivation

I approach this research as a complete community member with 15 years of experience in competitive debate across multiple roles: debater, judge, coach, and organizer. This insider perspective informs my reformist motivation to improve formats that have both shaped and limited the community I value. I believe debate is a class of role-playing games with immense transformative potential, yet the design of major formats remains calcified, with game design theories and practices entirely absent from attempts to improve them.

1.3 Problem Statement

Although a very diverse range of debate formats are played all over the world, the practice seen in other games of iterative improvement of the game based on discoveries in game design is entirely absent, most formats being deeply calcified. Their competitive communities evolve new "metas", modes of play and inpterpretations of rules, without game design supervision. These are poised to lead, in time, to a pattern of accepting instead of solving the issues in the design of these formats. For example, based on my fifteen years of observation, participation, and informal conversations with fellow practitioners, I believe and hypothesize that the two most popular debate formats, World Schools and British Parliamentary, whose communities in Europe are deeply intertwined, exhibit the following problematic tendencies:

First, they seem to push debaters towards value convergence, potentially causing them to become less tolerant of people with different values and diminishing their ability to convince people from different backgrounds. Second, they appear to teach debaters to speak very fast and with extreme information density, which could diminish their ability to meaningfully support their positions to people not trained as debate judges. Third, in my opinion they push communities towards competitive hierarchical behavior that undermines psychological safety.

These observations, while grounded in extensive practitioner experience, have not been systematically validated through empirical research and this thesis does not intend to extensively prove them, although a later section will present their echoes in literature. Throughout this thesis I have tried to design a format that addresses these hypothesized problems, and through the design process, to generate evidence about how these problems are triggered by and are solvable through the design of the game.

1.4 Research Question

How can the application of transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that manages to elevate its transformative potential (improved critical thinking, improved discourse, self empowerment etc) by addressing the issues of value convergence, discourse speed and community hierarchy?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This thesis aims to demonstrate proof of concept: that alternative debate formats can be systematically designed to address problems, and that such designs produce observable and articulable differences in participant experience. In particular it attempts to demonstrate how a debate format can address one or more of the identified problems without sacrificing entertainment value, competitive appeal or educational potential.

The thesis does not aim to produce robust claims about long-term educational efficacy or entertainment value, as such claims would require longitudinal studies with larger samples than a master's thesis permits. Its main contribution to knowledge is the simple proof that debate formats can be designed better if looked at as roleplaying games. To that end, two playtest sessions were conducted over two months with experienced debaters from the Romanian debate community, together yielding three design iterations. The results of both playtests are analyzed in the Results section of this thesis, where observational and debrief data are evaluated across five fields relevant to the format's transformative potential.

2 BACKGROUND AND LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Topic Overview

2.2 Debate as Transformative Game

Academic debate formats are games. Following Salen and Zimmerman (2004), a game is a system in which players engage in artificial conflict, defined by rules, resulting in a quantifiable outcome. Academic debate satisfies all criteria: rules, participants, winners, losers, tournaments, and scoring systems. Alfred Snider's 1982 doctoral dissertation at the University of Kansas, along with his subsequent publication (Snider, 1984), established the scholarly foundation for viewing debate as a game while documenting its educational benefits.

But what makes a game *transformative*? Bowman et al. (2025) conceptualize transformative role-playing games as those intentionally designed to encourage personal and social

change arising from play. For complete transformation to occur, this change must expand beyond the bounds of the original experience and integrate into the participant's daily frames of reality and identity. Daniau (2016) conceptualizes this transfer as one "from play skills to human skills," showing through action-research how participants in transformative role-playing games engage across four levels of reality (character, player, person, and human being) and, through structured debriefing, convert in-game abilities into lasting personal competencies. By this standard, a game is truly transformative not merely when participants report enjoyment or in-game learning, but when the experience produces lasting changes in cognition, behavior, or self-concept. The question for academic debate, then, is whether it meets this threshold.

Forensics pedagogy documents debate's transformative potential across several domains that satisfy this criterion. The most extensively studied is critical thinking: debaters develop the ability to recognize stated and unstated assumptions, evaluate causal inferences, and assess the validity of arguments (Colbert, 1995/2002; Hill, 1993/2002). Beyond cognitive gains, debate serves as a vehicle for empowerment, particularly for previously "silenced student populations" who develop their own voice through the activity (Snider, 2003), with Urban Debate Leagues leveraging this potential in academically challenged environments. The activity cultivates what Hicks (1998/2002a) calls a "democratic ethos": the capacity to justify convictions in public, respect minority views, and evaluate opposing arguments critically. Oral communication proficiency develops through audience adaptation, where students learn to analyze listeners' beliefs and norms to frame compelling narratives (Cirlin, 1997/2002), while parliamentary formats foster extemporaneous thinking and speaking (Whitmore, 1998/2002). Debate also functions as a "laboratory" for intensive research and information management (Broda-Bahm, 2002), with the intensity of high-level preparation frequently compared to master's thesis work (Combs, 2002a). Finally, debate provides a socialization mechanism, integrating students into a sub-culture with specialized language that enhances their sense of belonging to an intellectual community (Cirlin, 1997/2002; Kargacin, 1998/2002). Crucially, these effects are not confined to the debate round itself. They transfer into participants' academic performance, professional communication, and civic engagement, satisfying the criterion of transformation beyond the game.

Empirical research substantiates these claims, with quantitative evidence accumulating across critical thinking, academic achievement, and college readiness over several decades. Allen et al. (1999) conducted a meta-analysis of studies examining forensics and communication education, finding a significant positive relationship between such training and gains in critical thinking (longitudinal designs $r = .18$, cross-sectional designs $r = .20$), with forensics participation demonstrating the largest effect among the communication activities studied. At the individual study level, Colbert (1987) conducted the most comprehensive investigation, tracking 275 CEDA and NDT debaters and non-debaters across nine universities over a full academic year. Using analysis of covariance controlling for pretest scores, he found that debaters' Watson-Glaser Critical Thinking Appraisal scores rose from 61.18 to 64.53 while non-debaters' scores actually declined from 52.67 to 49.14, with NDT debaters significantly outgaining non-debaters ($F = 31.77$, $p < .001$). While Hill (1993/2002) cautioned that the broader body of debate-critical thinking research remained inconclusive due to methodological limitations and inconsistent results across sub-samples, Colbert (1995/2002) responded that the preponderance of evidence establishes "presumptive proof" favoring a

positive debate-critical thinking relationship, particularly when properly designed studies using robust statistical controls are considered.

Beyond critical thinking, debate participation correlates with substantial academic outcomes. Mezuk (2009) analyzed data from the Chicago Debate League spanning 1997 to 2006 and found that participants were 70% more likely to graduate and three times less likely to drop out than comparable non-participants, even after controlling for eighth-grade test scores and grade point average. Debaters were also more likely to meet ACT benchmarks for college readiness in English and reading, though not in science or mathematics. A subsequent expanded study of the same program by Mezuk et al. (2011), analyzing 9,145 students of whom 2,449 participated in at least one CDL tournament, found that debaters were 2.5 times less likely to drop out, graduated at a rate of 90% compared to 75% for non-debaters, and achieved a mean twelfth-grade GPA of 3.23 compared to 2.83 for their peers. Most recently, Schueler and Larned (2025) examined policy debate in Boston Public Schools serving large concentrations of economically disadvantaged students and found positive impacts on English Language Arts scores of 0.13 standard deviations, equivalent to 68% of a full year of average ninth-grade learning. Critically, these gains were concentrated on analytical rather than rote subskills and were largest among the lowest-performing students at baseline, with additional evidence of positive effects on high school graduation and postsecondary enrollment.

Forensics scholars have proposed several theoretical frameworks to explain how debate produces these transformative effects, each grounded in established learning theory. At the cognitive level, Colbert (1995/2002) argues that critical thinking develops through what he calls "intellectual disequilibrium," a concept rooted in Piaget's constructivism, where confrontation with opposing positions forces learners to restructure their mental models rather than simply absorb new information. Debate's adversarial structure ensures this confrontation is unavoidable: a debater cannot ignore the opposing case but must engage with it directly, producing the cognitive conflict that drives accommodation. At the communicative level, Cirlin (1997/2002) draws on Richard Weaver's rhetorical theory to show that debate develops persuasive skill through audience adaptation: debaters must continuously analyze their listeners' beliefs and norms to construct compelling narratives, a practice that transfers to communication contexts outside the activity. At the social level, Cirlin provides a sociological account of how participation integrates students into a discourse community with shared analytical vocabulary and norms of evidence evaluation. This linguistic socialization, which Cirlin describes through Weaver's concept of "sermonic" language, reshapes how participants perceive and engage with arguments in ordinary life. At the civic level, Hicks (1998/2002a) argues, drawing on Rawls's ideal of public reason, that debate cultivates a "democratic ethos": the disposition to justify convictions through publicly accessible reasoning, to respect minority views, and to evaluate opposing arguments on their merits. Drawing these threads together, Bellon (2000) synthesized evidence from competitive forensics, communication pedagogy, and educational psychology, including research on active learning and the social construction of knowledge, to argue that debate is a uniquely effective pedagogical tool precisely because it engages all of these levels simultaneously. However, these forensics-specific frameworks have not been connected to broader theories of experiential and transformative learning. In the Theoretical Framework section of this paper, I apply Vygotsky (1978)'s zone of proximal development to the scaffolded learning that occurs

through debate coaching and graduated competition, map Kolb (1984)'s experiential learning cycle onto the iterative process of debating, receiving feedback, and refining strategy, and draw on research into structured debriefing in simulation and role-playing (Crookall, 2014; Daniau, 2016) to illuminate how debate's built-in oral critique enables the reflective processing essential to lasting transformation.

Although forensics pedagogy has successfully documented debate's transformative effects and proposed explanatory mechanisms, I have yet to find any paper that analyzes major debate formats from a game design perspective or presents academic debating as a role-playing game, though Bowman (2014) acknowledges related pedagogical approaches such as process drama, classroom debates and simulation as role-playing games. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated conceptual tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, yet these have not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap in literature, applying game design lenses and expertise to the analysis and improvement of debate formats, is the main contribution to knowledge that I seek to start making through this paper.

2.3 Debate as Role-Playing Game

In the World Schools format, the one I will most focus on in this paper, in every debate there are two teams which receive a motion (e.g., "This House Would legalize the possession of drugs"). Teams are randomly assigned to opposite sides: Proposition/Government or Opposition. They deliver alternating speeches as if they were individuals supporting or opposing the motion. Judges listen as someone with no opinion on the motion, expert in debate rules, and averagely informed, deciding who most convinced the character they role-play. The debate ends with the judge ruling who won, explaining their decision and then offering feedback for improvement to the teams.

Understanding debate's relationship to role-playing games requires first establishing what role-playing games are and where debate fits among related practices. As Zagal and Deterding (2024) observe, defining role-playing games is notoriously contentious, with scholars, designers, and practitioners disagreeing across forms, styles, and communities. However, certain characteristics commonly recur: role-playing games are play activities revolving around the rule-structured creation and enactment of characters in a fictional world, where players define and pursue their own goals with considerable choice in what actions they can attempt (Zagal & Deterding, 2024). Bowman et al. (2025) offer a functional definition: analog role-playing games are "co-creative experiences in which participants immerse into fictional characters and realities for a bounded period of time and improvise through spontaneous, emergent playfulness" (p. 16).

Transformative game design literature explicitly positions debate among "cousin forms" of analog role-playing games (Bowman, 2014; Bowman et al., 2025), alongside simulations, educational role-playing, improv theatre, and psychodrama. The distinction rests not on the act of role-playing itself, which is much the same regardless of community, but on practices, norms, and innovations developing within each community. For the analytical purpose of usefully employing the body of theory developed to explain how and how better can role-playing games harness positive transformative energies, this is already enough to justify the following section. As will be later revealed, most of the theory developed within the Nordic

larp tradition explains processes common to all role-playing activities. Going even further however, competitive debate occupies an unusual position among these cousin forms, one that warrants closer examination. While debate is indeed used in educational contexts, it differs fundamentally from close cousins such as work simulations or classroom exercises in ways that bring it closer to analog role-playing games proper. Three theoretical dimensions illuminate this proximity: the depth of character immersion, the strength of alibi, and the leisure-community dimension.

First, regarding immersion: As opposed to work simulations or boardgames, debate requires players to genuinely inhabit an epistemic stance, constructing and defending arguments as if they believed them. This process of active perspective-taking requires what Bowman (2010) describes as adopting a theory of mind, thinking "as if" one were someone else in a unique set of circumstances (p. 57). The debater must anticipate objections, identify weaknesses, and respond to challenges as someone who holds the assigned position, a cognitive demand that approaches the immersion into character central to role-playing games. As Seo (2022) observes, "the moment one received a motion, one adopted the mindset of a person who was completely convinced of that point of view. One clung to this feeling of absolute conviction to make arguments, sink objections, and display passion" (p. 222). Rules also encourage speaking passionately: Snider (1999) instructs debaters to speak "with energy, enthusiasm, commitment, and variety" and to "act like you care about the arguments" (p. 65). I myself felt, and many colleague debaters also expressed, how the extreme cognitive load that performance in debate demands is incompatible with not fully assuming for the duration of the debate the opinion demanded by the motion, only to then discard it easily in time for the next debate (especially in a competition). Seo corroborates this from the inside: "Midspeech, a speaker rarely experiences the physical strain of thinking so damn hard. The adrenaline induced a mental fogginess that numbed the hard edges of experience" (p. 159). This passionate delivery, especially in the context of such extreme cognitive load, is difficult to sustain through meta-cognitive simulation alone. Affective role-assumption becomes the efficient path, organically eliciting rather than faking the emotions expressed.

Bowman (2010) identifies nine types of relationships between players and characters, including the "Fragmented Self," where a facet of the player's personality or interests becomes magnified into a central character trait. Debate characters fit this framework: they represent fragmented selves whose defining feature is epistemic commitment to a particular position. The debater role-plays as someone who believes the motion should pass or fail, adopting that argumentative perspective as the character's core identity. They find in themselves beliefs they can hold that support the position and banish from thought all other, focusing on a fragment of their identity.

Second, regarding alibi: this concept describes how game participants can act with lessened social consequences, encouraging risk-taking and willingness to fail (Deterding, 2017). Debate provides robust alibi through its competitive frame. Because debate is "just a game," debaters can advance positions they might not advocate publicly and explore uncomfortable arguments. Seo (2022) captures this vividly: the random assignment of sides provided a paradoxical "sense of freedom," allowing him to "flirt with ideas, unencumbered by expectations of consistency or deep conviction" (p. 20). Work simulations do not offer that. This enables the identity experimentation that Bowman et al. (2025) identify as central to transformational containers. It is important to accept that debate however, as all competitive

games, does require debaters to perform at and judges them by their peak intellectual ability, not offering them alibi to fail. I would argue however that many TTRPGs and boffer LARPs are designed requiring players to perform intellectually, and that roleplayers within certain communities feel pressure to display acting ability and ability to deeply emotionally immerse. In mainstream North American boffer LARPs, for instance, players who "break game" risk derision or ostracism (Brown, 2016), while in Nordic larp communities, immersion into character is often treated as an indicator of success, with its absence experienced as personal failure (Harder, 2018; Pohjola, 2015). They all however offer players alibi to hold a different identity. Alibi to fail is not essential to a roleplaying game, but alibi to assume the mantle of a character is. On that metric, debate offers players a very strong alibi to embody a character with deeply different opinions from their own: what Seo describes as tracing "the steps of how a sensible person (us!) could arrive at conclusions that might otherwise have seemed alien" (p. 224).

Third, regarding the leisure-community dimension: competitive debate possesses passionate discourse communities distinguishing role-playing games from cousin forms. The World Schools and British Parliamentary circuits encompass hundreds of competitions. Debaters participate voluntarily, often for decades; they develop specialized terminology, shared references, and community norms; they attend tournaments analogous to gaming conventions. The activity is often pursued for its intrinsic satisfactions, not merely as preparation for external goal. This leisure dimension, combined with the vibrant discourse community, positions competitive debate closer to role-playing games than to the educational simulations with which it shares surface similarities.

Furthermore, evidence for debate's role-playing dimension appears throughout its practice. Experienced coaches regularly employ explicit role-playing techniques during preparation, asking debaters to "become" stakeholders affected by policies. Furthermore, debate ethos as I witnessed it is summoned through traditions that explicitly stage parliamentary fiction: bench-pounding, heckling, Points of Information delivered as if holding onto wigs. The format performs a fiction of parliamentary deliberation, with debaters and judges alike participating in theatrical conventions inherited from eighteenth-century British debate culture.

Genuine differences between debate and games that are more traditionally seen as analogue role-playing games, such as Dungeons and Dragons, are undeniable: debate lacks the narrative worldbuilding, the character backstories, and the extended campaign structures of tabletop or live-action role-playing. But it is important to recognize that debate's role-playing operates through the same psychological mechanisms and this justifies applying the substantial body of transformative game design scholarship to understand how debate produces its educational effects and, more importantly, how design choices might enhance or undermine those effects.

2.4 Literature Review of Format Critiques

The usefulness of applying transformative game design theory to attempt solving the problems of current debate formats comes also from the apparent failure of current scholarly works in the same endeavor. The largest body of work that analyzes debate as an educational tool is that of forensics pedagogy. This centers around the more predominant formats

played in the US (especially American Policy). I will thus focus on reviewing what literature was written that echoes the problems I set out to solve and that forms arguments that are also applicable to the formats that I seek to improve (especially the World Schools format).

2.4.1 The Technical-Public Sphere Tension

A fundamental critique pervading the literature concerns the evolution of debate formats away from public sphere accessibility toward technical sphere insularity. Combs (2002b) documents how both NDT (National Debate Tournament) and CEDA (Cross Examination Debate Association) have evolved into technical sphere activities characterized by: expert-level topic knowledge, speaking rates exceeding what most listeners can process, sophisticated analytical models inaccessible to non-specialists, heavy reliance on extensive note-taking, and specially trained judges.

This has effect both on my critique on value converge as well as related to public speaking abilities.

2.4.2 Value Convergence and Ideological Homogenization

A significant concern in the literature relates to what I coined above as value convergence. The "closed system" dynamic described by Harris and Smith, cited in Combs (2002b), creates conditions conducive to value convergence. In academic debate, tournament practices are insulated from external feedback and where judges who deviate from community norms are "effectively excluded from the system much like the human system rejects certain bacteria" (Combs, 2002b, p. 40). This dynamic may cultivate shared assumptions that, while facilitating intra-community communication, potentially diminish debaters' capacity to engage persuasively with those holding different values.

Crenshaw's work on feminism in debate, cited by McGee (2002), illustrates how "argument borrowing" can lead to reductionist treatment of complex intellectual traditions. Debaters observe which arguments succeed in out-rounds, then adopt those lines of reasoning for their strategic value rather than out of genuine engagement with the underlying ideas, producing superficial understanding and reduced capacity for authentic cross-ideological dialogue.

2.4.3 Delivery Practices and Communicative Capacity

Colbert, cited in Combs (2002b), found that average CEDA debaters spoke at approximately 237 words per minute, while NDT finalists averaged 284 words per minute, with some exceeding 300 words per minute, rates that "greatly exceed what is considered optimal for normal speaking" (Combs, 2002b, p. 36).

While World Schools and British Parliamentary formats explicitly discourage talking fast through style-based evaluation, similar pressures toward information density exist. In my observation, this occurs because these formats evaluate on two officially co-equal axes—Style (or Manner) and Content (or Matter)—yet increasing information density improves argumentative quality (more points addressed, more rebuttal, more nuance) while simultaneously reducing intelligibility and persuasive clarity. Because debate operates in an academic setting where the analysis of argumentative quality is perceived as more objective and measurable

than the assessment of style, the competitive meta gradually shifts toward privileging Content over Style, even though the evaluation rubric formally treats them as equally important. The result is that the skills developed may not transfer to contexts without expert judges. The difficulty to solve this is also captured in literature. (Hicks, 2002b) treats the difficulty of defining for what type of audience should debaters make themselves persuasive, comparing Weiss (2002)'s "audience standard" (being understandable to a regular audience) to his "ideal of public reason" (being understandable to the perfect rational listener), presenting how some educational value is lost either way.

2.4.4 Hierarchical Dynamics and Psychological Safety

In this issue I have observed forensics pedagogy literature is thinnest, yet several authors recognize the risk. Snider (1999) addresses safety and ethics in his Code of the Debate, and in his later practical guide warns organizers to "avoid a counterproductive rigid and hierarchical organization," noting "I've seen groups die when they let ego and status get in the way" (Snider, 2014, p. 36). The International Debate Education Association's ethics guide for coaches and youth workers similarly acknowledges the "unbalanced power dynamic" inherent in coach-student relationships, compounded by the fact that "older debaters often mentor younger teams" and thus occupy dual roles of peer and authority figure (International Debate Education Association, 2024). Riley and Hollihan further suggest that approximately three years of debate experience are required to compete effectively on the national circuit, effectively excluding students without extensive preparation and reinforcing experience-based hierarchies (Combs, 2002b, p. 38).

The mechanism behind these dynamics is illuminated by recent research. Prus and Sikora (2025), citing Simon et al. (2020), note that "people placed in competitive intellectual situations tend to develop an adversarial mindset" characterized by myside bias and otherside bias, distorting cognitive appraisal of the issues being debated. They identify competitive debate's "most crucial weakness": its rules "do not allow for saying to the opponent: 'You are right, I was wrong'" instead training debaters to listen for omissions and inaccuracies rather than for understanding (Prus & Sikora, 2025, p. 1474). When win-loss records become the primary measure of status within these hermetic communities, the adversarial structure produces natural hierarchies in which winning debaters gain social authority while losing debaters are marginalized, reinforcing competitive pressure at the expense of collaborative learning.

2.5 Gap Identification

This literature review reveals a significant gap. Forensics pedagogy has established debate's educational benefits and identified tensions, but has not systematically applied game design frameworks to analyze how specific format mechanics produce specific effects. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, but has not been applied to competitive debate. Addressing this gap is the central contribution of this thesis.

3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This section develops an integrated framework synthesizing transformative role-playing game theory, learning theory, and procedural rhetoric to explain debate's transformative mechanisms and guide design decisions.

3.1 Core Theoretical Constructs

3.1.1 The Transformational Container

The concept of the transformational container originates in the psychoanalytic work of Winnicott (1960) and was adapted to role-playing game theory by Bowman and Hugaas (2021). It describes a bounded space in which consent is emphasized, boundaries are established, and content is calibrated to maintain psychological safety, enabling participants to take risks and experiment with new ways of being (Baird & Bowman, 2022; Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Bowman et al., 2025). The transformational container builds upon but extends Huizinga (1958)'s concept of the "magic circle": whereas all games can be said to possess a magic circle demarcating play from ordinary life, a transformational container additionally requires explicit goals, safety structures, and community support oriented toward lasting personal change (Bowman et al., 2025). I argue that debate, in its existing forms, already constitutes a partially-realized transformational container. The format's explicit rules and conventions (speaking times, turn order, permissible modes of engagement) establish boundaries that demarcate the debate encounter from ordinary social interaction, much as ritual framing guides participants into a liminal space (Bowman et al., 2025). Within these boundaries, the competitive frame provides what Deterding (2017) terms *alibi*: because side allocation is typically random and the activity is understood as a game, the reason a debater advances a given position is "I was assigned this side," not "I personally believe this." This deflection of inference from displayed behavior to the game's structure reduces social risk, granting participants permission to explore unfamiliar arguments, adopt perspectives they might not publicly endorse, and fail without lasting reputational consequences. The judge, meanwhile, functions as the containing authority analogous to the facilitator in transformative game design (Bowman et al., 2025): a figure who maintains the rules, calibrates the encounter through feedback, and structures the post-round evaluation that helps participants process the experience. However, as Bowman et al. (2025) caution, a container's effectiveness is not guaranteed by its mere existence; communities that fail to support participants may interrupt transformative processes. If competitive pressures become so intense that tournament success conflates with personal worth, the alibi weakens as participants can no longer treat debate as "just a game" and the container's transformational potential erodes.

3.1.2 Bleed as Transformative Mechanism

Following Hugaas (2024), bleed describes the bidirectional spillover of psychological contents between player and character (or in debate, between the debater and their assigned position). This concept is crucial for understanding how debate produces its educational effects. Leonard and Thurman (2018), drawing on Lankoski and Järvelä (2012)'s grounded cognition

framework, provide neuroscientific grounding for bleed: embodied cognition means that inhabiting a role activates neuropsychological processes that do not fully distinguish fictional from real experience, with hormonal responses associated with trust and social bonding operating in character-mediated interactions just as they do in ordinary life. Moreover, compartmentalizing in-character reactions requires self-regulatory control, a limited resource that depletes during sustained effortful performance. Applied to debate, this framework suggests that extended rounds of inhabiting an assigned position gradually erode the cognitive separation between debater and debater-character, helping explain why sustained debate practice can produce lasting attitudinal shifts.

Memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and perspectives, explains how debaters should develop what I call epistemic humility: an attitude of skepticism towards one's own opinions, being open to understand the beliefs of others and to accept them as valid. First of all through the very direct memetic bleed of the opinions of the role played in a debate towards the debater, arguments which can be summoned again outside of the debate. But more than that, after years of arguing for positions contrary to their beliefs, debaters bleed into accepting that reasonable people can formulate opposing views, that anything can be argued convincingly, and that argumentative power does not equate with being right. This mechanism provides a theoretical account of what forensics scholars have documented empirically: Colbert's "intellectual disequilibrium" (Colbert, 1995/2002), the cognitive conflict produced by engaging with opposing positions, describes the trigger that opens the channel for memetic bleed, while the "democratic ethos" that Hicks (1998/2002a) identifies as debate's civic outcome is the intended result of that bleed integrating into the debater's empowered attitude.

This bleed of a certain humble attitude connects to Bogost (2007) concept of procedural rhetoric. Bogost argues that every game, though its systems and rules, reflects a certain world-view, that players in time may be persuaded of. The rules of debate inherently postulate that anyone can support anything and that through dialectic processes of presenting arguments for and against, not truth is reached, but a showcase of who is more capable in argument (as two opposite decisions could be taken in two different rounds on the same motion). Thus experienced debaters ideally learn to acknowledge how there may be much truth in the points made also by the less skilled in argument.

Procedural bleed, the transfer of physical abilities and habits, explains skill development. The rhetorical habits, speaking patterns, and argumentative reflexes developed through competition bleed into debaters' ordinary communication, producing the documented improvements in public speaking and critical thinking. Cirlin (1997/2002)'s account of how debaters develop persuasive skill through audience adaptation (outlined above as learning to analyze listeners' beliefs and norms to construct compelling narratives) describes precisely this form of procedural bleed and its transfer beyond the activity.

Emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) explains debate's particular power for students from marginalized backgrounds. For students where eloquent public speaking was not modeled, debate provides a transformational container (Bowman & Hugaas, 2021) to discover and develop their voice. Being taken seriously as intellectuals, having ideas weighed on merits rather than dismissed based on identity, produces lasting changes in self-concept and capability. Snider (2003)'s documentation of debate empowering previously "silenced student populations" through Urban Debate Leagues provides empirical evidence for this

form of bleed in competitive debate contexts.

3.1.3 Zone of Proximal Development and Scaffolded Learning

Vygotsky (1978) zone of proximal development explains how debate creates naturally occurring scaffolding: power-pairing ensures challenges remain within the zone where growth occurs, while judges provide guided instruction through post-debate feedback. The debate cycle naturally embodies Kolb (1984) experiential learning model, with the debrief, which Crookall (2014) and Daniau (2016) identify as essential to transformation, built into debate through the oral critique. This scaffolding explains why the "intellectual disequilibrium" that Colbert (1995/2002) identifies as debate's cognitive engine produces growth rather than frustration: coaching, graduated competition, and structured feedback keep the cognitive challenge within the zone where productive accommodation occurs. Hammer et al. (2024) provide a framework for understanding how RPG-specific affordances, including perspective-taking through character portrayal, collaborative engagement through shared imagination, and identity experimentation—interact with broader constructivist and sociocultural learning processes. This framework supports the claim that analogous mechanisms are present in competitive debate: switch-side argumentation cultivates perspective-taking comparable to character portrayal in RPGs, while collaborative team preparation mirrors the shared imaginative construction that Hammer et al. identify as central to RPG-based learning.

3.2 Reframing Forensics Pedagogy Critiques through Transformative Game Design

The critiques identified within forensics pedagogy, echoing the issues identified during the problem statement, can be productively reframed through the theoretical mechanisms of transformative game design, illuminating not only why these problems occur but also suggesting design-based interventions.

3.2.1 Value Convergence as Corrupted Memetic Bleed

What I coined as value convergence can be seen as a failure in memetic bleed. The intended transformative outcome of debate is epistemic humility. However, memetic bleed is mediated by judges, creating vulnerability to what I term *evaluative bleed-in*. Judges role-play as neutral arbiters, but this role is cognitively demanding and vaguely specified. When judges share common backgrounds, their collective bleed-in produces systematic biases.

Following Bowman et al. (2025), the container's effectiveness requires psychological safety for all participants, including judges. When judges face social consequences for heterodox opinions that deviate from "emancipatory rhetoric" community consensus, the alibi protecting experimental judgment erodes. What bleeds into debaters is the community's strategic equilibrium rather than appreciation for intellectual diversity. Debaters, optimizing for competitive success, do "argument borrowing", adapting strategically: arguments that succeed in elimination rounds or from high-status debaters become templates, and approaches aligned with perceived judicial values propagate.

Design interventions might therefore diversify audiences debaters must persuade, strengthen judge alibi through structural features, and explicitly distinguish in debriefing between "what wins debates" and "what constitutes good reasoning."

3.2.2 Information Density and Misaligned Procedural Bleed

The critique of information-dense speaking represents misalignment in procedural bleed. When formats reward rapid delivery optimized for expert judges, debaters develop procedural habits adapted to highly specific audiences. The skills that bleed out are real but narrowly optimized, representing failure of transfer.

Design interventions might include evaluation criteria rewarding accessibility alongside substance, or judging paradigms simulating general audiences. By constructing vivid characters for judges to role-play, the bleed-in from character to judge can itself become memetic, the judge taking on the character's understanding while maintaining expert-level rule comprehension.

3.2.3 Competitive Pressure and the Compromised Container

When competitive pressures become overwhelming, when tournament success determines status and self-worth, the alibi enabling transformation erodes. Participants can no longer treat debate as "just a game" because stakes have become too real. Bowman (2013) documents social conflict within role-playing communities arising from power differentials between facilitators and players, competitive play dynamics, creative agenda disputes, and unprocessed bleed. These patterns parallel competitive debate: power differentials map onto hierarchies between experienced and novice debaters, competitive play produces status systems based on tournament success, and creative agenda disputes manifest as exclusion of those whose approach does not conform to community norms.

This compromise cascades through other mechanisms. Emancipatory bleed requires a container where being taken seriously is possible; rigid hierarchies block this for those positioned as subordinate. The zone of proximal development requires calibrated challenges; competitive anxiety may prevent productive struggle or reflective observation.

Design interventions might distribute status more broadly, emphasize growth over victory, strengthen alibi by making explicit the distinction between game performance and personal worth, and incorporate safety practices adapted from larp design (Bowman et al., 2025).

4 METHODS

4.1 Design Philosophy

This research employs Research through Design (RtD) as primary methodological framework. RtD positions the design process itself as inquiry, where knowledge emerges through making and iterating upon designed artifacts (Coulton & Hook, 2017; J. Zimmerman et al., 2007). The design process follows E. Zimmerman (2003) iterative methodology, treating play as research. Each playtest generates data informing subsequent decisions, creating a spiral of refined understanding.

4.2 Development Process

Development unfolds through three cyclical phases. In the generation phase, I explore potential mechanics addressing theoretically-identified problems, using brainstorming sessions, design conversations with debate peers, and analysis of existing formats. In the critical scrutiny phase, I evaluate whether candidate designs congruently address problems without introducing new difficulties (e.g., judge cognitive load, time limitations), using the theoretical framework as evaluation criteria. In the validation phase, surviving elements undergo increasingly rigorous testing: informal design conversations with experienced debaters, small pilot playtests identifying mechanical problems, and a larger playtest as a mini-competition with structured observation and interview protocols.

These phases spiral until the format demonstrates sufficient coherence, playability, and alignment with transformational goals, or allocated resources run out. The first playtest (one debate) was held in March 2026 at the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest, with senior debaters aged 18–20. A second design iteration was drafted based on its findings. The second playtest was conducted in April 2026 with seven veteran debaters in a familiar informal setting, yielding a third design iteration. Both sessions are documented in Annexes A–G.

4.3 Research Methods

For analyzing the quality of the design, two playtests were organized. During these sessions the research methods used were participant observation and structured post-session debriefs, followed by qualitative data analysis.

4.3.1 Participant Observation

Following Baker (2006), I adopted a participant-as-observer role during both playtest sessions. My researcher status was known to participants, and I participated actively in the second session to obtain firsthand understanding. When observing debates where not participating, I functioned as observer-as-participant: present and known but not actively engaged.

Observation focused on overall debate flow and more granularly on behaviors relevant to entertainment value, rule legibility and adherence ease, and elements distinct from standard formats, judging whether these indicate positive or negative tendencies vis-à-vis identified problems and the theoretical framework's predictions.

Informed by the advice of Spradley (1980), I recorded field notes in two phases: condensed and expanded. Condensed notes, taken during debates, captured key moments, quotations, and behavioral observations using structured protocols. Expanded notes, written within 24 hours of the sessions, elaborated, added contextual observations, and recorded analytical reflections. Both sessions were audio-recorded with participant consent to enable field note verification and capture verbal content not fully documented in real-time.

Observation spanned two structured playtest sessions over two months.

4.3.2 Participants

Debaters were recruited for both sessions with the aid of ARDOR Muntenia, the NGO managing the debate community in Bucharest and the south of Romania. They directly inquired various clubs about including a playtest as part of their weekly activity and issued open calls for debaters in organizing the sessions.

In Romania, the young adults (not minors) debate community is quite homogenous regarding debate experience, as almost all are senior debaters with training experience. Many of these are students or professionals living in Bucharest. The sample answering my open call will likely be representative in debate experience for the most probable target outside this research: experienced, not novice, debaters.

The majority of Romanian debaters are minors. Ideally, the study would involve minor participants, but ethical guidelines pushed toward this strategy as best alternative.

The two sessions involved a total of approximately fifteen participants. This sample size is consistent with the proof-of-concept nature of the research: the goal is demonstrating that design-based interventions can produce articulable differences in experience, not establishing generalizable population-level effects.

4.3.3 Post-Session Debriefs

Structured post-session debriefs complemented observation by accessing perspectives not directly observable. Following each session, participants completed a structured debrief form (Annex C) covering general experience (positive/negative, contrast with other formats, perceived difficulty), intentions to play in this format again, and reflections on specific mechanics. The debrief form was developed based on the theoretical framework's predictions about transformative mechanisms.

Debrief discussions occurred immediately following each session, ensuring fresh recall. They were conducted in person and supplemented by the researcher's reflexive notes recorded within 24 hours.

4.4 Data Analysis

Analysis follows a design-oriented comparative approach. The primary purpose is not generating generalizable theory but informing ongoing design decisions and articulating how the designed format produces different experiences than existing formats. This aligns with experimental game design methodology (Waern & Back, 2015), where design experimentation becomes research when "the aim is to understand something generic, some more fundamental aspect of game design."

Between playtest sessions, rapid analysis focused on actionable insights: what mechanics worked and should be preserved, what did not work and caused confusion or disengagement, and what surprised me and suggested new opportunities. This treats playtesting as "play as research" (E. Zimmerman, 2003), with each session generating questions informing the next design cycle.

After the second playtest, systematic comparative analysis proceeded through three phases. First, initial coding following Lankoski and Björk (2015) identified and labeled

data segments describing participant experiences, behaviors, and reflections with descriptive rather than interpretive codes. Second, comparative code analysis organized codes into categories structured around theoretical constructs, coding for continuity (experiences similar to traditional formats), difference (experiences diverging), and novelty (experiences unique to the designed format). Third, articulation of design principles connected observed effects to specific format mechanics, examining relationships between game components, player actions, and goals.

This approach can demonstrate: (a) the designed format produces experiences participants describe as different; (b) specific mechanics appear connected to specific differences; and (c) differences align with intended goals. It cannot demonstrate persistence, superiority, or generalizability, appropriate limitations for proof-of-concept Research through Design where contribution lies in demonstrating that systematic design can address identified problems and in articulating design principles meriting further investigation or usage.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

This research adheres to Uppsala University's ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. All playtest participants were informed of the purpose and context, how data would be gathered, stored, and analyzed, both during and after recruitment. All were able to offer and retract consent, granularly or wholesale, to participation in every process part and to data being collected, stored, or used. Peers whose input was used in developing this format were informed of context and credited. All data is stored securely in encrypted Microsoft OneDrive offered by Uppsala University, separated by content type, and will be deleted once thesis development and presentation is complete. All data has been anonymized and is not publicly available.

To ensure psychological safety, the rigorous ethical standards imposed by the ARDOR Ethical Guide and ARDOR Trainer Safety Guide will be followed. Debate topics will avoid personal trauma topics and debaters will be able to refuse to engage with motions. Debaters will be able to always talk to a third-party equity officer regarding emotional safety issues and report abusive or distressing behavior. During debates, all debaters will be able to exit without explanation.

Beyond these, all participants will have pre-session briefing and post-session debrief providing chances to address potential distressing elements before activity and discuss experience afterwards.

4.6 Positionality and Reflexivity

I approach this research as a complete community member (Adler & Adler, 1987). My fifteen years in competitive debate have shaped not only my knowledge but my values, assumptions, and emotional investments. This informs several positions I must acknowledge: insider knowledge enabling nuanced understanding but potentially creating blind spots; reformist motivation emerging from genuine frustration with existing formats, predisposing me toward confirming my critique; a novel disciplinary lens through game design rather than the educational or rhetorical frameworks common in forensics scholarship; and power dynamics created by my status as former Team Romania coach and successful debater, which may

influence participant responses. My competitive success within the formats I critique creates additional tension regarding whether my familiarity enables recognition of subtle issues or obscures problems I cannot fully perceive.

To support reflexive awareness, I maintained a reflexive journal and followed each debrief session with a reflexive note (Knott et al., 2022), actively seeking data contradicting expectations. Given that some participants were known to me, recruitment was externalized to ARDOR Muntenia staff, and data from participants with close prior relationships was flagged while triangulating self-report data with observational data where possible.

Scope Note The original design of this study envisioned approximately four iterative playtest sessions. In practice, two sessions were completed within the thesis timeline. While this reduces the breadth of iterative feedback, both sessions yielded substantive observational and debrief data sufficient for proof-of-concept assessment. The implications of this reduced scope are discussed in the Results chapter.

5 DESIGN OF THE INSIDE OUT FORMAT

5.1 From Theory to Design

This chapter corresponds to the generation and critical scrutiny phases of the Research through Design methodology outlined in the Methods chapter. The theoretical framework produced three design predictions constituting the design brief. The Inside Out format is presented in full in Annex A, and annexes B-D present its chronological evolution; the following sections argue why each structural element exists and how it serves the theoretical objectives.

5.2 Design Rationale

Each structural choice in Inside Out traces to the theoretical framework's diagnosis of how traditional formats produce corrupted bleed, misaligned skill transfer, and container compromise. This section justifies the format's core design decisions.

5.2.1 Why Multiple Teams Defending Values?

Traditional formats position two teams in binary opposition, a structure whose procedural rhetoric (Bogost, 2007) teaches that every issue has exactly two sides. Inside Out replaces this with three Value Defender teams, each advocating for a different value held by the Subject. This restructuring addresses several identified problems simultaneously.

The multi-team structure produces a procedural rhetoric of complexity and humility: the format asserts through its rules that decisions involve balancing multiple legitimate human values, not choosing between right and wrong. This directly counters the corrupted memetic bleed driving value convergence by positioning value pluralism at the core of the conflict rather than treating it as a side effect of switch-side argumentation. Because values are assigned rather than chosen, the design also strengthens alibi (Deterding, 2017) for assuming

a fragmented identity (Bowman, 2010), the debater-character relationship is explicitly about inhabiting a value, making perspective-taking the core mechanic. And because the Subject is a person with specific background, circumstances, and values rather than an abstract decision-maker, the motion reinforces that decisions are products of context, resisting the abstraction that enables generic argument templates and the drift toward what Goodnight (1982) identified as the technical sphere of argumentation.

Furthermore, the structure cultivates collaborative alongside combative skills. Value Defenders must persuade the Subject, a sympathetic listener making a genuine decision, not defeat an opponent. This corrects the misaligned procedural bleed by developing communication habits adapted to contexts beyond competitive debate, where persuasion typically involves collaboration rather than combat (Cirlin, 1997/2002). The Subject also creates a natural accessibility incentive: if a Value Defender speaks incomprehensibly, their arguments are simply not weighed in the decision, a consequence that recalibrates the zone of proximal development (Vygotsky, 1978) toward general-audience communication without any external rule imposing it.

5.2.2 Why Split Subject and Evaluator?

In traditional formats, a single judge both determines the winner and provides feedback, entangling evaluation with adjudication. Inside Out separates these functions: the Subject makes decisions within the debate, while the Evaluator observes and offers commendations.

This split means winning the debate is not a goal in itself but a method for growing, symbolized through commendations rather than victories. Decision-making within the debate becomes an act not of arbitrating but of synthesizing toward a position by acknowledging the interplay between values, a form of procedural rhetoric that models how real-world deliberation works, steering corrupted memetic bleed away from value convergence and toward epistemic humility. Moreover, the Subject's defined character invites bleed-in from character to debater, making the player less receptive to unpersuasive high-density argumentation precisely because the character they inhabit would not be. The Subject learns to synthesize; the Value Defenders learn to persuade collaboratively; and the Evaluator, freed from adjudicating competition, can focus on recognizing communicative virtue, maintaining the transformational container by decoupling status from competitive victory.

5.2.3 Why Commendations Instead of Scores?

Replacing scores and victory with commendations moves the format from a paradigm of competing against others toward one of improving oneself. The commendation system recognizes individual worth: the aspiration is not to become the best debater, but to become the best form of debater one can become. Two debaters can be excellent in entirely different ways, a message reinforced by the diversity of commendation categories ("Compassionate Discourse" alongside "Strategic Rebuttal") and the badge progression system that builds unique skill profiles over time. This directly addresses the container compromise identified in the theoretical framework: when status derives from demonstrated growth rather than competitive victory, the zero-sum dynamics that erode the transformational container (Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Bowman et al., 2025) are structurally dismantled.

The commendation system also resolves a persistent tension in modern debate formats between content density and persuasive discourse, precisely the misaligned procedural bleed identified in the theoretical framework. Commendations dissolve this conflict: debaters can pursue recognition for persuasive discourse alongside and equally with recognition for academic rigor and complexity, because these are separate categories rather than competing dimensions collapsed onto a single scale.

5.2.4 Why Oral Feedback Instead of Oral Critique?

In traditional formats, the oral critique centers on the judge's decision: the judge explains who won and why, and advises debaters on what would have changed the result. The implicit question is "how could I have won?" Inside Out reframes post-round interaction as oral feedback, centering on demonstrated skills and developmental trajectory. The Evaluator explains the commendations awarded, articulates why particular moments demonstrated particular skills, and offers advice oriented toward growth. The implicit question shifts to "what am I developing, and how can I develop further?" This connects the debate experience to the debater's broader growth trajectory rather than to a single round's competitive outcome, maintaining the transformational container by structuring the debrief around growth rather than victory.

Several tensions in this design constitute productive questions for playtesting. Will competitive motivation survive without win-loss outcomes, or will debaters socialized in traditional formats experience commendations as insufficient stakes? The Subject team bears a unique cognitive burden in synthesizing three value streams, and whether this is productive challenge or overwhelming difficulty depends on experience level and motion complexity. The format's novelty (four teams, new roles, unfamiliar mechanics) may create barriers to entry for newcomers. Without victory as evaluative anchor, commendation judgments may feel more subjective; clear criteria and Evaluator training will likely be essential.

6 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

This chapter addresses the central research question:

> How can the application of transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that manages to elevate its transformative potential—improved critical thinking, discourse quality, and self-empowerment—by addressing the issues of value convergence, discourse speed, and community hierarchy?

The question admits two decomposed sub-questions. First: can a method of applying transformative game design theory to this problem domain be demonstrated? Second: does that method yield expected results? Each is addressed in turn.

6.1 Demonstrating the Method: The Design Process as Contribution

The first sub-question is answered by the thesis itself. The preceding chapters document a systematic progression from theoretical analysis (Sections 2 and 3), through iterative format design grounded in design theory principles (Section 5), to empirical testing and reflection. This sequence constitutes a worked example of how transformative game design theory can be operationalized in a competitive debate context. The design decisions recorded in Annexes A, B, and G—and the reasoning connecting each iteration to observed player behavior—demonstrate that such an application is coherent, achievable, and produces testable outcomes. Whether or not the resulting format succeeds transformatively, the method of application has been rendered explicit and repeatable.

6.2 Evaluating the Results: Evidence from Playtests

The second sub-question concerns whether the designed format shows signs of achieving its intended effects. Two playtests were conducted: the first in March 2026 with senior debaters from the Jean Monet debate club in Bucharest, and the second in April 2026 with seven veteran debaters in an informal setting. Field notes, structured debrief responses (Annex C), and post-session reflections constitute the primary data.

It is important to frame what this data can and cannot show. Given the small sample size, the absence of control conditions, and the exploratory nature of the design, the collected data cannot prove the format's effectiveness. What it can provide are *clues*—observed behaviors, reported experiences, and emergent patterns—from which educated inferences about potential effectiveness may be drawn. The following analysis examines clues across five evaluation fields. A full enumeration of identified clues, with explanations of what each points toward and why, is provided in Annex H.

6.2.1 Field 1: Engagement, Appeal, and Long-Term Viability

For a debate format to sustain a community, it must be sufficiently engaging to generate voluntary, repeated participation. Several clues suggest the Inside Out format clears this threshold.

Players across both playtests spontaneously expressed that the format was enjoyable. In the first playtest, participants described it as "surprisingly liberating" and reported "a lot less anxiety" than in standard competitive rounds. In the second playtest, the Huddle phase was described by multiple participants as "very very fun," and players indicated they would choose to play again, noting they would try to be "more emotionally immersed" on a second encounter. The organic adoption of format vocabulary—participants spontaneously referring to each other as "inner voices" during the second playtest, a term not present in the ruleset—suggests genuine imaginative investment.

A significant finding is the differential appeal across participant profiles. Women and debaters who had been less successful in traditional formats expressed strong preference for Inside Out. This suggests the format reaches constituencies underserved by standard competitive debate, potentially expanding the participant base rather than merely offering an

alternative experience to existing enthusiasts. The one participant who found the format unsatisfying was a highly competitive debater who missed the "ego-boosting" feeling of decisive victory—a response consistent with the format's design intent to deprioritize individual dominance.

6.2.2 Field 2: Productive Pressure Mechanisms

Competitive debate's transformative potential depends partly on pressure: the cognitive and social demands of the activity push participants to grow. A format without sufficient challenge risks becoming a low-stakes social exercise without developmental benefit. Clues from both playtests suggest Inside Out retains meaningful pressure while redistributing its character.

Participants in the first playtest noted that "architecting solutions" was "very complex and interesting strategically." Rather than reducing the cognitive challenge, the format redirected it: instead of constructing chains of consequences or maximizing argumentative coverage, players found themselves navigating value hierarchies, contextual reasoning, and audience empathy. This represents a shift in the *kind* of intellectual pressure rather than a reduction in degree.

The Commendations system (Annex A) provides a recognition mechanism that acknowledges growth without binary win/loss outcomes. While facilitators in both playtests noted that commendations were challenging to assign without clear performance targets, participants who received them reported the recognition as meaningful. One evaluator observed that in a larger circuit, commendations would become more organic—pointing toward a format whose evaluative culture could mature with practice.

6.2.3 Field 3: Growth Direction—Useful Skills and Perspectives

A central design goal was to redirect the skills debate develops toward more transferable outcomes: persuasive communication, perspective-taking, contextual reasoning, and collaborative discourse. Clues from both playtests suggest this redirection was partially achieved.

In the first playtest, participants articulated learning to "think about the context of decisions," to be "more human and more honest about human nature," and to recognize that "sometimes decisions are personal, not universal." These reflections align with the format's procedural rhetoric (Bogost, 2007): the rules of Inside Out encode a world in which personal context and value conflict are central to decision-making, and players appear to have internalized aspects of this world-view through play.

The second playtest produced particularly notable evidence of perspective-taking. All players immediately adopted a roleplay-oriented stance, speaking directly to the Subject, using second-person address, and adding contextualizing details to the motion. This spontaneous behavior—not explicitly instructed in the ruleset—suggests that the format's structure reliably elicits the kind of imaginative engagement associated with perspective-taking bleed (Hugaas, 2024). The Subject player's reflection on how the opening speech led them to "expose some nuanced biases"—a bleed of player into character, and character reasoning back into player—represents a concrete instance of the memetic bleed mechanism theorized in Section 3.

6.2.4 Field 4: Community Dynamics and Reduced Toxicity

One of the design's primary goals was to reduce the hierarchical and adversarial dynamics that contribute to attrition and harm in competitive debate communities. Several clues suggest the format meaningfully shifts these dynamics.

The most striking finding was the cultural norm that emerged spontaneously during the second playtest: participants noted that "outright attacking others' points feels wrong, disrespectful, and unnecessary." This was not a rule imposed by the format but a norm that emerged from the format's structure—a textbook example of procedural rhetoric reshaping participant behavior (Bogost, 2007). Players found that shifting focus and building on others' contributions felt "more natural and more persuasive" than traditional rebuttal, suggesting a genuine rhetorical culture shift.

Both playtests confirmed significantly reduced anxiety. Participants across both sessions described the experience as "much much less anxiety-inducing" than standard competitive debate, while still finding it stimulating and structured enough to sustain engagement. One participant offered an important nuance: the reduced anxiety may partly reflect the format's lesser established status, so that less social capital is staked on performance. This is an honest limitation to note—whether anxiety reduction would persist in an established Inside Out circuit is an empirical question for future study.

6.2.5 Field 5: Epistemic Humility

The deepest transformative aim of the Inside Out format is to cultivate epistemic humility: a disposition to take multiple perspectives seriously, to recognize the validity of different value frameworks, and to hold one's own conclusions with appropriate uncertainty. Clues from both playtests point toward the format supporting this outcome.

In the first playtest, participants explicitly articulated a version of epistemic humility: "every team says valuable stuff and it is important more to see what is important to us." This recognition—that competing perspectives each contain genuine insight—is the precise attitudinal outcome theorized in the bleed and procedural rhetoric frameworks of Section 3.

The second playtest produced two particularly notable pieces of evidence. First, the spontaneous drift toward consensus in the second round of Value Defender speeches: rather than competing to "win," players naturally moved toward finding the most defensible synthesis of values. This behavior, not incentivized by the evaluation structure, suggests the format's procedural logic orients participants toward integration rather than domination. Second, the unplanned bleed effect: a participant shared, unprompted during a break, that the debate scenario "hit uncannily close to home" because a family member had asked them that same day to provide false testimony. This moment of real-life resonance demonstrates the Inside Out format's capacity to activate personal value reflection—precisely the transformative mechanism the design aimed to support.

6.3 Proof of Concept Assessment

Taken together, the clues documented across both playtests provide reasonable grounds for a proof-of-concept claim. The format:

- was experienced as engaging and appealing, particularly by participants underserved by traditional formats;
- maintained sufficient intellectual pressure through a redirection rather than removal of challenge;
- elicited spontaneous perspective-taking, value exploration, and contextual reasoning;
- generated emergent community norms oriented toward collaborative rather than adversarial discourse; and
- produced instances of epistemic humility, bleed effects, and personal value resonance consistent with the theoretical framework's predictions.

No single piece of evidence is conclusive. Small sample sizes, the absence of longitudinal follow-up, and the researcher's dual role as designer and observer all limit what can be inferred. However, the convergence of multiple independent clues across two separate playtest groups—each producing similar patterns of engagement, anxiety reduction, and spontaneous norm formation—provides a coherent picture that justifies continued investigation. The format warrants further empirical study with larger groups, more experienced facilitators, and longitudinal measurement of the skill and attitudinal outcomes theorized here.

6.4 Limitations

The original design of this study envisioned approximately four iterative playtest sessions. Two were completed within the thesis timeline. While this reduces the number of design iterations and the breadth of participant exposure, both sessions yielded substantive observational and debrief data sufficient for proof-of-concept assessment. Future work should extend the iterative cycle.

The researcher's insider position as a fifteen-year competitive debater and the format's designer is both a strength (enabling nuanced interpretation of participant behavior) and a limitation (creating potential for confirmation bias in clue selection and interpretation). Reflexivity notes were maintained throughout, and the Annex H clue list explicitly notes the evidential strength and directionality of each inference.

Finally, both playtest groups consisted of experienced debaters already familiar with competitive formats. The format's performance with novice participants—for whom the contrast with standard debate would be less salient—remains untested.

7 Conclusion

Alfred "Tuna" Snider was first to recognize debate as a game and to apply play logic to its analysis, doing this way before game design was a recognized discipline. Through his career as a teacher and scholar he championed the transformative power of playing this game with joy, passion and determination. Although many of his students, one of whom I was very privileged to be, did continue his work in fields such as civics, education, rhetoric and his own specialty of forensics, none used game-design know-how to answer the question that

most naturally flows from his argument that debate is a game: how can we make it a better game?

This thesis seeks to begin answering that question. By applying transformative game design theory to competitive debate, it aims to demonstrate that systematic design interventions can address identified problems while preserving debate's documented benefits. The contribution lies not in producing a finished format but in establishing proof of concept: that the intersection of game design scholarship and forensics pedagogy offers productive tools for format improvement, and in articulating design principles worthy of further development and investigation.

Annex A — Inside Out Debate Format: First Design Iteration

The **Inside Out** format is an experimental debate format, designed using best practices from tabletop RPG game design. It seeks to be a more *fun*, *performance-growth oriented*, and *real-life skill-building* alternative to traditional competitive debate formats. Rather than winning arguments, debaters explore values, make meaningful decisions, and earn recognition for the skills they demonstrate.

7.0.1 Team Structure

Debaters are organised in four teams of two debaters each and are assigned positions within the debate at random:

- **Team S (Subject):** Represents the Subject of the Motion — the person who must face a decision. Must weigh all values and choose.
- **Teams A, B, and C (Value Defenders):** Each argues that a particular Value held by the Subject should be prioritised in the decision, and consequently, what the Subject should decide.

7.0.2 The Motion

The Motion outlines:

- What is the decision that has to be made.
- What is the background of the Subject and other relevant practical factors that can be taken into account within the decision.
- What are the three Values of the Subject, each assigned to one Value Defender team.

It is important to note that the Motion does not prescribe to the Value Defenders a particular position on what decision the Subject has to make. They have to construct it themselves.

7.0.3 Speech Order

The four teams hold alternating speeches in the following order:

A1, B1, C1, S1, A2, B2, C2, S2

Within their speeches, the Value Defenders argue for the relevance of their value, construct a specific decision that best honours it, and engage with the arguments forwarded by the other Value Defenders.

Within their speeches, the Subject team must outline a strong reasoning that engages with and explains the interplay between all arguments of the Value Defenders, picking a particular decision. Within S1 they pick a preliminary decision and within S2 a final decision.

7.0.4 Evaluation

The debate is overseen by an Evaluator, who performs two tasks:

Commendations. The Evaluator awards Commendations to debaters. Commendations represent acknowledgements of useful skills, knowledges, or attitudes. A list of awardable commendations is constructed by the Chief Evaluators of the Debate Tournament, along with the total number of Commendations that Evaluators can offer within that Tournament. Example commendations include Believable Passion, Witty Solution, Argument Ingenuity, and Resilience (see Section 9 of this Annex for the full list).

Over time, debaters who gather a particular commendation at least three times earn a Badge. Gathering it additional times upgrades the badge, an unlimited number of times, but each upgrade requires gathering three more Commendations than last time.

Oral Feedback. The Evaluator delivers an Oral Feedback session, in which they explain to each team the commendations they received, the reasoning behind them, and give advice on how each debater can improve in the future based on their performance.

7.0.5 Example Motion

> You are the parent of a 16-year-old teenager. Your family is middle class and lives in the suburbia of a metropolis. You have higher education. You live in a country in which Higher Education is free, but there are only a few universities that are deemed as good. The year is 2026. You evaluate that your kid is talented in music, is a good leader and has had very good STEM skills, but is also quite distracted, does not have many friends and has failed to learn a foreign language. Your kid expressed a moderate interest in studying Musicology at university after they finish high school, but is also considering not going to higher education. You have a good relationship with your child. They asked you to suggest what they should do. What do you recommend your kid they should do after they finish high school?
>
> Three Beliefs that you hold, relevant for this decision, are:
>
> - In life, financial stability and independence is essential for a happy life.
> - It is important to be a well-rounded, cultured individual.
> - The people that you surround yourself with end up defining who you are.

7.0.6 Comparison with Traditional Formats

The table below contrasts Inside Out with World Schools debate along six dimensions.

	World Schools	**Inside Out**
Teams	2 teams × 3 members	**4 teams × 2 members**
Sides	Proposition vs. Opposition	**3 Value Defenders + 1 Subject**
Motion style	"This House…" policy/value motions	**Personal dilemma with background & values**
Goal	Win the argument — defeat the other side	**Explore values — help the Subject decide**
Evaluation	Scored on Content, Style & Strategy (points)	**Commendations for skills & attitudes (badges)**
Outcome	Win / Loss + speaker rankings	**No win/loss — growth-oriented feedback**

Key shift: Inside Out moves from adversarial persuasion to collaborative deliberation. There is no winner — instead, debaters earn commendations that recognise individual skills, and the Subject synthesises all perspectives into a reasoned decision.

7.0.7 Player Instructions

Value Defenders.

- Formulate arguments for why your value is **important, useful, and relevant** to this dilemma.
- Propose a **specific decision** that best honours your value — argue why it is right and leads to good outcomes, especially through the lens of your value.
- Engage with other Defenders' **values**: show yours is more important, more relevant to the dilemma, or safer to follow.
- Engage with other Defenders' **decisions**: attack, support (claiming it maximises your value), or endorse with addendums — choose your positioning wisely.
- Your core mission: **define what honouring your value looks like** in practice, and persuade the Subject it is the right path.

The Subject.

- **Enter without an opinion.** You are completely torn — you are here to listen and be persuaded, not to argue.
- Listen as if you *are* the Subject: **let the speeches move you** as they would move this person.
- Also take a mental step back: **evaluate how persuasive each argument would be** for the Subject, and adjust your lean accordingly.

- Take notes on arguments and their interplay — record what the Defenders say, **not your own personal thoughts**.
- **Collaborate quietly** with your partner: you are both embodying the same person, not competing.
- In your speeches, share which decision you are leaning toward and **why**, weighing all arguments to the extent they were persuasive. You must pick a specific decision, not merely name a value.

The Evaluator.

- Analyse the debate and each player's performance. Decide which **commendations** to award — aim for one per debater (the same commendation can go to more than one person).
- Approach the round as an **educator** helping each player grow, not as a judge declaring a winner.
- Open with a **narrative of the debate** from your outside perspective: what each team did and how it all unfolded.
- Engage directly with each team: ask what they **felt they did well** and what they found difficult. Share your view and add your own observations.
- Ask each team what they want to **do better next time**, and give concrete advice on how to get there.
- Close by **awarding commendations** to each player.

7.0.8 Rituals

Rolling In.

1. **Team commitment chant** — Each team member states their commitment aloud before the debate begins:

   Subject: *"I am [character name]. I am open to being moved."*

   Each Defender: *"I believe in [value]. I will argue from that belief."*

Rolling Out.

1. **Subject's thanks** — The Subject team thanks each Defender individually: *"Thank you for speaking your truth."*
2. **Defenders' thanks** — Each Defender team thanks the Subject: *"Thank you for listening and carrying the decision."*

3. **De-roling** — Everyone stands. Each person states their real name and shakes hands with every participant: *"I am [name]. Thank you for playing with me."*

4. **Bleed check** — The Evaluator asks quietly: *"Did anything in that debate feel close to home for anyone?"* — a brief, optional moment to name any emotional residue before moving into feedback. No one is required to answer.

7.0.9 Full Commendation List

Commendations are organised across five categories. Each commendation has three award tiers: *Earned* (threshold quality), *Strong* (clear excellence), and *Exceptional* (reserved for outstanding, rare performances). Some commendations carry role restrictions (Defenders only, or Subject only) as noted.

Style *(6 commendations — delivery, presence, and rhetorical quality)*

Believable Passion. You were truly invested in your point, showing genuine, believable conviction and care for the value you defended. Distinct from Honest Connection (self-disclosure) and Broad Range (technical delivery control).

Earned Tone conveyed genuine care at key moments; voice quality shifted naturally, eye contact held at key claims, word choices felt spontaneous.

Strong Conviction was felt in the substance of the speech; the room or the Subject visibly reacted.

Exceptional The delivery made the dilemma feel real and worth deeply caring about. Reserve for speeches where the affective dimension was genuinely transformative.

Entertaining Discourse. The speech was genuinely enjoyable through wit, lightness, or a well-timed observation that made the room smile or lean in. Distinct from Poetic Appeal (literary craft).

Earned At least one moment was distinctly enjoyable: a clever comparison, a light touch, or a well-timed observation.

Strong Liveliness was woven into the argumentation consistently; humor or vividness served to make points land more effectively.

Exceptional Entertainment and argument were seamlessly fused throughout, reaching the level of a sharp public talk where wit and substance were inseparable.

Broad Range. Your delivery showed impressive stylistic range, varying tone, rhythm, tempo, and volume to serve the speech. Distinct from Believable Passion (authenticity of feeling); rewards technical delivery control.

Earned At least two noticeably different delivery registers were used; the speech did not feel flat.

Strong Variation was deliberate and purposeful: shifts in pace or tone coincided with structural moments in the argument.

Exceptional The full palette was deployed with mastery; the debater controlled the room's attention through delivery alone.

Honest Connection. Something genuine about yourself entered the speech — a real disclosure rather than a rhetorical move — that created contact between the debater and the room. Distinct from Believable Passion (conviction); rewards self-disclosure and personal presence.

Earned At least one moment of genuine self-disclosure (an admission, first-person reflection, or personal statement of feeling) that felt real rather than strategic.

Strong The personal register appeared at key structural moments; eye contact moved around the room, direct second-person address, or deliberate pause.

Exceptional The speech was uniquely theirs; you felt the debater was genuinely present in the room with you.

Poetic Appeal. Language was used with aesthetic care, where rhythm, imagery, or metaphor elevated the speech as a piece of writing, independent of its entertainment value. Distinct from Entertaining Discourse (enjoyment response); rewards literary and rhetorical craft.

Earned At least one passage was noticeably well-crafted: a sentence that would stand alone as good writing, or a rhythmic construction that made a point feel inevitable.

Strong Poetic quality sustained across multiple moments; rhetoric served the argument.

Exceptional The speech had genuine literary quality; specific lines are still in your head afterward. Language itself became part of the argument.

True Embodiment. You convincingly inhabited your role, arguing and deciding from inside it rather than about it from outside. For the Subject: thinking, feeling, and deciding as the character. For Defenders: arguing from genuine conviction in the value.

Earned The role's reality guided the speech throughout; stated leanings tracked the actual arguments made.

Strong The embodiment elevated the entire round; you could see the speaker being moved, reconsidering, weighing.

Exceptional Not applicable; omit Exceptional tier for this commendation.

Strategy *(7 commendations — positioning, framing, and tactical intelligence)*

Specific Topicality. Arguments were sharply specific to this dilemma, this Subject, and these values, with no generic claims. Distinct from Advantageous Framing (evaluative lens); rewards the content of the arguments themselves.

Earned Most substantive claims grounded in the specifics of the motion: the Subject's background, the values as stated, the actual decision at stake.

Strong Topicality was strategic; the debater drew on details others missed.

Exceptional Every substantive move calibrated to this specific situation; the arguments would fall apart if the Subject or dilemma were changed.

Advantageous Framing. You defined the terms of discussion in a way that benefited your position before others could. Distinct from Specific Topicality (argument content) and Helpful Guiding (neutral Subject navigation).

Earned Explicitly established a coherent evaluation framework relevant to their value's claim.

Strong The framing did real structural work; other debaters had to address it, and the Subject engaged with it directly.

Exceptional The framing was original and visibly influenced the course of the debate. Award rarely.

Witty Solution. You proposed a concrete, value-informed solution to the dilemma, specific enough that it could only have come from someone defending your value. Distinct from Advantageous Framing (criteria); rewards the solution itself.

Earned The proposed solution was specific and thought through, demonstrably flowing from the defended value.

Strong Notably smart: navigated a genuine tension between values, or revealed an angle others missed.

Exceptional Elegant and surprising, more persuasive than alternatives precisely because of how the value was applied.

Brave Pivot. You changed position or conceded a point honestly, and it made your case stronger.

Earned Explicitly acknowledged an opponent's point had merit, or adjusted position in response to what was said.

Strong The pivot was strategic: conceding less important ground to better defend more important ground.

Exceptional Changed their mind in real time under pressure, arguing why the pivot extends rather than contradicts the previous position. Award with corresponding rarity.

Efficient Alliance. *(Defenders only)* You recognized when another Defender's arguments complemented yours and built on that alignment.

Earned Acknowledged at least one point of genuine agreement with another Defender that strengthens the case for a decision.

Strong Explicitly constructed an alliance: "both Team A and I agree that X, which shows the Subject that the weight of argument points toward Y."

Careful Positioning. *(Defenders only)* Your stance toward other Defenders' decisions was deliberate and chosen rather than reactive, with positive effect.

Earned Response to other Defenders' decisions was evidently chosen rather than accidental; the stance was coherently maintained.

Strong Positioning was in service of a coherent strategy; you could reconstruct the reasoning behind every stance taken, forming a consistent picture.

Helpful Guiding. *(Subject only)* You helped the room navigate the structure of the debate clearly, accurately, and fairly. Distinct from Advantageous Framing; the Subject's role is neutral navigation, not partisan framing.

Earned At least one moment of genuine meta-level navigation, e.g. "the key question before us is now X, because Y has been established and Z has been challenged."

Strong The guiding was structurally important, identifying a genuine turning point or consolidating arguments fairly to all sides.

Content *(9 commendations — argumentation, analysis, and engagement with the debate)*

Word Economy. You communicated clearly and efficiently; every minute of speaking time counted. Rewards form of expression, not argument substance.

Earned The speech did not waste significant time; arguments were stated without excessive preamble, redundant restatement, or filler.

Strong Concision actively served clarity: complex ideas were expressed with precision; understood fully on first hearing.

Exceptional The debater said something hard to say in few words; specific lines had a density of meaning that rewarded attention.

Rebuttal Ingenuity. Your rebuttal identified a non-obvious flaw in an opponent's argument: a hidden assumption, internal tension, or unconsidered consequence. Distinct from Argument Ingenuity (novel constructive arguments) and Comprehensive Breadth (coverage).

Earned Identified a non-obvious weakness rather than the first available attack.

Strong Engaged with the strongest version of the argument and demonstrated why it fails even there.

Exceptional Changed the argumentative landscape; the rebuttal was difficult or impossible to satisfactorily respond to.

Rebuttal Prioritization. You made deliberate, strategic choices about where to concentrate your rebuttal effort, and those choices were correct. Distinct from Comprehensive Breadth (coverage); rewards deliberate focus over breadth.

Earned Concentrated force on the most important clashes, explicitly or implicitly flagging the allocation.

Strong Prioritization revealed genuine strategic intelligence; the choice of what to ignore was as deliberate as what was attacked.

Rebuttal Accuracy. You represented opponents' arguments faithfully before responding — no mischaracterization, no straw-manning. No Exceptional tier; accuracy is a threshold quality. Award only when faithful representation was genuinely non-trivial.

Earned Paraphrased opponents' arguments correctly; engaged with the most charitable understanding.

Strong Engaged with specific moments in specific speeches; accuracy made the rebuttal more effective, not just fairer.

Robust Logic. Your arguments were well-constructed: valid, plausible, and without significant logical gaps. Distinct from Impressive Argumentative Depth; logic asks whether the reasoning chain holds structurally.

Earned Main arguments had clear claim-warrant-impact structure; a reasonable person could follow without supplying missing steps.

Strong Logic held up under challenge: no internal contradictions, no steps requiring the audience to take things on faith.

Exceptional Genuinely tight; would require a sophisticated objection to dislodge; obvious objections anticipated within the argument itself.

Impressive Argumentative Depth. You went beyond the surface, interrogating implications, mechanisms, or philosophical roots. Distinct from Robust Logic (structural soundness) and Argument Ingenuity (novelty).

Earned At least one argument went meaningfully beyond its initial claim, explaining why the value's demand is well-founded or what it would look like for the Subject to live by it.

Strong Depth sustained throughout; consistently pushed past surface-level argumentation.

Exceptional After the speech, you found yourself reconsidering something you had assumed you understood, or the argument illuminated a dimension of the value no other speech had touched.

Comprehensive Breadth. You engaged with the full scope of the debate, including inconvenient arguments. Distinct from Rebuttal Ingenuity (sharpness) and Rebuttal Prioritization (deliberate focus); rewards attentiveness across the full debate.

Earned Addressed the most important arguments from all other Defenders, not only the weakest or most convenient.

Strong Demonstrated careful listening throughout; the speech reflected the actual state of the debate.

Exceptional Managed to synthetically yet explicitly cover every significant aspect of the debate.

Argument Ingenuity. You produced an argument that was unexpected, non-obvious, and substantively illuminating. Distinct from Rebuttal Ingenuity (reactive) and Impressive Argumentative Depth (thorough development); rewards novelty and surprise.

Earned At least one argument was notably fresh: not typically heard in this kind of debate, logically coherent, and able to withstand an obvious first objection.

Strong Ingenious in the full sense: first surprised you, then convinced you, revealing something about the value or dilemma that prior thinking had missed.

Exceptional The argument changed the debate; others had to respond to it and it became a fixed reference point. Very rare, award accordingly.

Accurate Synthesis. *(Subject only)* You gave a fair, accurate, and well-organized account of the full state of the debate. Distinct from Comprehensive Breadth (Defenders' engagement); rewards the Subject for faithfully describing and weighing what happened.

Earned Correctly identified the main arguments from each Defender and did not misrepresent or omit them, even where unfavorable.

Strong Showed genuine comprehension of the debate's structure: an account of how arguments interacted, where they clashed, and what the real decision points were.

Exceptional Identified the strongest and weakest versions of each Defender's case and grounded the final decision in a genuinely comprehensive account of the round.

Fairplay *(3 commendations — observe team dynamics & debrief, not only speeches)*

Teammate Support. You actively helped your partner formulate something difficult in a way that visibly contributed to the team's performance. Look for: visible collaboration during prep time; a second speaker building clearly on something the first struggled with. Award when the help was substantive and its impact visible. Ask in the debrief if not fully observable.

Teammate Solidarity. You showed genuine support for your partner during a hard moment, without distancing yourself. Look for: body language and verbal behavior toward a partner after a difficult moment; a second speaker who picked up where a struggling first left off without implicitly throwing them under the bus. The difficult moment must have been real and the solidarity genuine. If ambiguous, ask in the debrief.

Strategic Problem-Solving. You demonstrated intelligent, adaptive problem-solving in the face of strategic challenges in the round. Look for: a visible strategy adjustment that worked; a debater who recognized a weakness in their own case and addressed it explicitly; coordinated strategic adaptation across both speeches. Both identifying and solving the problem must be visible and shared between the two team members.

Growth Mentality *(4 commendations — use the debrief; always name the specific moment in feedback)*

Applied Feedback. You visibly tried to apply feedback from a previous round; imperfect application still earns this. Evidence may come from direct comparison with a prior round or from the debater's own account in the debrief. What matters is the genuine attempt rather than the outcome.

Out of Comfort Zone. You attempted something genuinely difficult for you and made a real go of it. Rewards the attempt, not the result. Comfort zone is individual; use the debrief to identify what was genuinely challenging. Ask directly if needed.

Tracking. You showed clear awareness of your own growth across debates: where you started, what you have worked on, and where you are heading. Distinct from Applied Feedback (applying specific feedback in one round); rewards the broader self-awareness of one's development arc over time. Evidence may come from the debrief: the debater can articulate what they have improved, name skills still being worked on, and describe their trajectory with accuracy.

Resilience. You encountered a genuinely difficult moment and came out intact, or stronger. The difficult moment must have been real. Award for: a strong attack responded to with a composed second speech; a delivery stumble overcome mid-speech; an unexpected move handled with adaptability. Name the specific moment in feedback; this commendation must be concrete to be useful.

Annex B — Inside Out Debate Format: Second Design Iteration

The second design iteration is based on observations and participant feedback gathered during the first playtest (Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026). The changes below supersede the corresponding elements in the first iteration (Annex A).

7.0.10 Speech Order Changes

The interstitial S1 speech between the first and second rounds is removed. In its place, two new elements are introduced:

S0 — Subject Opening Speech. A new opening speech before any Defender speaks. The Subject team introduces the dilemma and argues why it is genuinely hard: all three values are relevant, the decision is real, and there is no obvious right answer. This speech gives the debate proper gravitas before Defenders begin.

The Huddle. A 10-minute interval inserted after C1 (and before A2). The Subject team may ask direct questions to any Defender team, grant them the floor to answer, and revoke their right to speak at any point. The Huddle allows the Subject to control the conversation toward resolving argumentative tensions, forcing arguments that need to interact to interact.

Thinking Time. A 2-minute silent thinking period is added before S2, giving the Subject team time to integrate all arguments before delivering their final decision.

The new speech order is:

S0, A1, B1, C1, [The Huddle], A2, B2, C2, [2-min thinking time], S2

Points of Information (POIs) are introduced during all speeches: any debater may signal to the current speaker to ask a brief question.

7.0.11 Motion Changes

- The Subject character description in the motion should include a longer list of the Subject's personal beliefs and past decisions, to flesh out the character more fully and enable value-specific argumentation.
- Value Defenders should address the Subject in the second person ("you, as the Subject, should...") rather than in the third person, reinforcing the personal and direct character of the deliberation.

7.0.12 Evaluation Changes

Commendations are awarded in private: after the debate, the Evaluator approaches each team separately rather than delivering commendations in a public session. The oral feedback narrative and growth-oriented debrief remain public.

7.0.13 Speech Instruction Clarifications

- Subject instructions explicitly state that the Subject must pick a specific *decision* (a concrete course of action), not merely name a value they find most important.
- More explicit guidance is provided on what the Subject team should prepare during prep time: for S0, they should prepare to explain the dilemma's genuine difficulty and why all values are relevant; for S2, they should prepare to synthesise all arguments and justify a final specific decision.

Annex C — Debrief Form

The following questionnaire was administered to participants after the first playtest. Questions aim to gather data on entertainment value, format distinctiveness, participant intentions, and transformative effects.

1. How fun was the debate? (scale 1–10)
2. How fun was it compared to a debate in a traditional format? (5-choice scale)
3. Was there anything surprisingly entertaining or engaging about it?
4. Was there anything about the format that was quite difficult, to the point of frustration?
5. Was there anything about the rules of the format that was confusing?
6. Would you play this format some more? (Yes / No)
7. If you would play it some more, in what circumstance would you?
8. If there was to exist an alternative debate circuit centred around this format, would you attend those competitions? Even at the expense of competitions in the WS or BP format?
9. Do you believe you played differently than you would have in a debate in WS/BP with a rather similar motion? If so, how?
10. Do you feel different than how you usually feel after a debate? If so, how?
11. Did you perceive yourself and others speaking similarly or differently than how you do in a regular debate? If so, how?
12. Were you to redo this debate, what would you do differently?
13. Were you to play more in this format, but on different motions, what would you do differently?
14. What do you believe you learned from this debate?
15. What do you believe this debate format does better, as a learning/empowerment tool, than WS or BP? Do you believe it does something worse?

Annex D — Playtest Motion

The following motion was used in the first playtest at the Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026.

First version. Used in the first playtest at the Jean Monet debate club, Bucharest, March 2026.

> You are Alex. You are a lawyer. You are close to your older brother Matei. He is a very caring person to everyone, always eager to help even strangers. He always helped you when you were in need. However he was always quite dishonest with you, and you caught him lying even about important things. Matei is also an alcoholic and you believe he is quite bigoted.
>
> Matei was involved in a hit and run recently. He hit a cyclist that ended up hospitalised. The cyclist remembered his license plate only partially and he is now being investigated by the police. From your knowledge they only have circumstantial evidence, but he still risks going to jail. He asked you to lie that he was with you at home at the time of the accident, in order to provide him an alibi. Your assessment as a lawyer is that this will almost certainly exonerate him. However, a very small risk remains that additional material evidence could be found, at which point you might become an accessory to the crime.
>
> **What should you do?**
>
> Three Values that you hold, relevant for this decision, are:
>
> - You believe that helping people in need is very important, and a moral duty.
> - You believe in justice: that people should receive what they deserve.
> - You believe that family should stick together and have each other's back.

Second version. Used in the second playtest, April 2026.

> Alex is a criminal defence lawyer with seven years of experience. The eldest of three siblings from a small town, Alex was the first in the family to attend law school. After graduating, Alex spent two years at a legal aid clinic representing clients who could not afford private counsel, before joining a private firm. Alex's first major case there was defending a driver charged with causing serious injury in a road accident — Alex secured his acquittal.
>
> Matei is Alex's older brother and the two have remained close throughout their lives. Matei is known among everyone who knows him for being eager to help others, often going out of his way even for strangers. He helped Alex through several difficult periods. He has also been dishonest with Alex repeatedly over the years, including about important matters. Matei struggles with alcohol and holds a number of views that Alex finds bigoted.

Matei was recently involved in a hit-and-run: he struck a cyclist who was hospitalised. The cyclist recalled his license plate only partially, and Matei is now under police investigation. As far as Alex knows, the evidence against him is circumstantial. Matei has asked Alex to lie and say he was at home with Alex at the time of the accident. Alex's legal assessment is that this would almost certainly exonerate him, though a small risk remains that additional material evidence could surface — at which point Alex would become an accessory to the crime. **What should you do?**

Values:

1. You believe that helping people in need is very important, and a moral duty.
2. You believe in justice, that people should receive what they deserve.
3. You believe that family should stick together and have each other's back.

Annex E — Informed Consent Form

I, _____ of _____ years of age, voluntarily accept to participate in a playtest followed by an interview session, both moderated by Andrei Dan Olaru, as part of his *"Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate"* study. This study seeks to explore the creation of an alternative debate format, informed by modern transformative game design theory. I understand that:

1. This session implies video recording of the entire debate playtest and the subsequent collective interview, plus some additional questions using an online questionnaire.
2. Pseudonyms will be used when analysing the data for confidentiality, and the researchers commit to not revealing the identities of the participants. Individual raw data may be discussed in class or with the supervisor without the participant's name to trace back to. The data obtained will be analysed by grouping and some textual examples will be used anonymously.
3. The recording will be safely stored in the university's OneDrive to maintain the saved raw interviews protected. The video will be erased one month after the dissertation's results. The transcripts will be erased up to one year after the dissertation's results.
4. None of the questions will go against my integrity, no harm will come to me during this session, no answer is right or wrong and I may choose not to answer any question(s) without consequences of any kind.
5. I am free to walk out of the playtest and interview at any time if I deem it necessary without prejudice or any consequences.

For any additional information or difficulty, the participant may contact the researcher Andrei Dan Olaru at `andrei-dan.olaru.0744@student.uu.se`.

_____ _____

Participant's signature Researcher's signature

I, _____ have been informed of the conditions and freely accept to participate in the research by Andrei Dan Olaru.

_____ _____ of March 2026

Participant's signature Date

Annex F — Second Playtest Report

The following is a first-person account of the second playtest session, held in April 2026. The session gathered seven veteran debaters. Design changes arising from this playtest are documented separately in Annex G.

7.0.14 Setting

I held the second playtest together with seven veteran debaters, close friends. We held it at the apartment that part of us commonly rent and share with other nerds for the single purpose of playing TTRPGs there. Because of that, the main room is dominated by a hilariously large, roughly round table. We held the debate seated at it, which one player noted created a council-feel to the whole session — as opposed to a regular debate in which the seating mimics parliamentary discourse and thus feels profoundly more impersonal. I was not the Evaluator this time; I played as the second speaker of the A Inner Voice team.

7.0.15 The Brief

The brief took about 40 minutes — similar to how much it took with the high-schoolers. The fact that it required that amount of time even with people accustomed to parsing lengthy rulebooks speaks to how much the design differs from traditional formats. The division of the "judge" role into two separate individuals (the Subject and the Evaluator) was noted as interesting by several players. The role of the Subject was by far the hardest for players to understand, especially the purpose of the opening Subject speech. I had, at the point of writing the rules, found it genuinely difficult to pin down what the Subject should do in that first speech. I wrote vague guidelines — and this showed — but in the end I believe it was for the better: I let the player decide what would be most interesting and useful. In that I was fortunate: the role was drawn by a player with substantial game-design experience, a professional L&D background, many years as a trainer, and deep experience as a roleplayer.

7.0.16 Rituals

The roll-in rituals were experienced as cringe, and were surely too lengthy. Players felt they should be replaced by a short introduction from the Evaluator followed by a brief shared gesture or chant. This aligns with how regular debates open: the judge makes an introduction, then everyone bangs the table vigorously and the debate begins. One player noted that the rituals do recognise the effort put in by the judge — in this case shared between the Subject and the Evaluator.

The calling rituals were received positively.

The roll-out rituals were also too lengthy and became cringe, but one player noted they liked the way in which people express gratitude to everyone. The consensus was that this could be replaced by a moment of handshakes in which each person says a short phrase based on their role. Players also noted that calling a defender by name during the calling ritual felt unnecessary.

7.0.17 S0 — The Opening Subject Speech

The player who drew the Subject role delivered an interesting, roleplay-heavy speech — they even played a soundtrack. They fleshed out the motion with many evocative details that further emotionally contextualised the scenario, then tried to explain how they care about all three values and why each is relevant to the decision. This in part exposed some nuanced personal biases that bled from the player into the character. Several players — including that player — noted that this institutionalises the already existing practice of debaters "playing for the judge": attempting to exploit the judge's known biases. I found this observation striking. The speech, although I was sceptical of it initially, does hold a great deal of value: fleshing out the scenario, giving a floor for surfacing biases. What it needs is clearer language for what players are supposed to do.

7.0.18 First Round of Inner Voices

All players immediately adopted a roleplay stance. They spoke directly to the Subject, addressing them by name and in the second person, looking at them, and choosing speech patterns that mirrored those the Subject had displayed. They also took the liberty to add small details to the motion — to worldbuild.

I find this very promising but also somewhat concerning. Giving players unofficial worldbuilding powers may lead inexperienced players to twist the debate in an unhelpful direction. However, adding colour to the broad facts of the scenario does lend to a more realistic simulation of how people actually argue, raises emotional engagement, and heightens immersion.

It was interesting that even very veteran debaters struggled, especially in this first round, to both appeal to emotion and to argue specifically for their assigned value. Most focused on constructing interesting and nuanced Solutions and arguing why these were practical and useful — utilitarian and cerebral overall — except for the last team, who appealed explicitly to emotion, which set the tone interestingly for the second half.

Players also began referring to each other as "the other inner voices" — an organic renaming that feels more natural than "Value Defenders". I plan to adopt it.

7.0.19 The Huddle

Everyone found the Huddle very, very fun. The Subject player later said it was a genuine eureka moment when they realised they could ask particular Inner Voices to have very specific conversations with each other. It is worth noting that this player has meeting facilitation experience. During the Huddle, the Subject first asked each team to clarify things they were still confused about, then asked teams to expand on arguments they found particularly interesting, then asked pairs of Inner Voices to directly clash on issues they felt needed resolving.

At a certain point the Subject ran out of ideas for what to ask. I believe that with two players on the Subject team this would happen less frequently. Still, ten minutes felt too long — I would cut it to eight.

7.0.20 Second Round of Inner Voices

The Huddle exacerbated something that had already started in the first round: a slow drift toward consensus on what decision should be taken. The second round was much less about the practicalities of which decision is best, and much more about arguing which is the dominant lens through which the decision should be viewed.

My intuition is that something similar might happen with other groups, not only with veteran debaters.

During my own speech I also pivoted toward consensus on the right Solution. I did this because I found it interesting and novel — something regular debate never allows — and I wanted to see how it felt, to demonstrate that the rules permit it, and to explore whether I could deliberately fish for the "Brave Pivot" commendation. I found that I felt little need to rebut the points made by others; arguing for my lens and shifting focus felt like a more natural and persuasive strategy than attacking others, and I allowed myself to be openly persuaded by fellow Inner Voices on some points.

A fellow player later noted that in this format to outright attack what others say "feels wrong" — disrespectful and unnecessary — and that the format requires tact in how one goes about diminishing the relevance of another's points.

7.0.21 Second Subject Speech

The Subject player structured their speech quite like a regular debate adjudication: they explained what they understood each Inner Voice team to have argued and how convincing each case was, then expressed the solution they had reached and what had factored most in their decision. They later said that during the first speech they were in more of a roleplay mindframe, but that as the debate progressed they transitioned more and more to feeling and thinking like a debate judge.

My intention had been for the second speech to remain somewhat more roleplay-ish — the Subject speaking about how something *felt* persuasive, being a bit less analytical. I am not sure whether adjusting the instructions is needed, or whether this was simply the style of this particular player.

7.0.22 The Evaluator Speech

The Evaluator gave insightful feedback on how each of us could have been more persuasive to a regular person. She then noted it was very difficult to find feedback to give, because the format does not specify clearly toward what educational objectives the feedback should be directed.

This raised a broader question I should think about more: traditional debate exists within a complex, organic constellation of clubs and competitions. Most people tell themselves they do debate to learn — critical thinking, public speaking — and trainers and judges tell themselves they are there to teach useful skills. In practice, my sense is that the circuit has a life of its own, and that people invest effort on either side mostly for the social reputation it yields.

How should this format be played? Who should facilitate it? Who is it for? What should it help participants achieve?

Another interesting suggestion was that a structure allowing the Evaluator to be more actively involved — to facilitate and give real-time feedback, to encourage players — would be useful. I tend to agree. Renaming the Evaluator "the Facilitator" might help signal this.

The Evaluator also said that awarding commendations was difficult, and that in a larger circuit it would become easier: she would not feel pressure to give everyone a commendation and would reserve them for truly outstanding moments. She added that once the commendations were memorised the system would feel much more organic than the numeric speech-point quantification that most traditional formats require of judges.

7.0.23 On Bleed

I decided to skip the final bleed-releasing ritual, expecting it would feel awkward. It was interesting, then, that even without it, one of the players spontaneously shared during a brief intermission that the debate had hit uncannily close to home: on the way to the session, a family member had asked them to testify for them in court, which they had found morally wrong.

7.0.24 On Commendations

There was substantial discussion about the commendation system. The more "gamer" of the players expressed that it scratches a "make a build" itch, but felt that commendations should carry some bonuses as well. They also raised the concern that players might start farming them — choosing to play in unusual ways simply to collect a specific commendation and "complete" a build.

7.0.25 Participant Feedback

Most players expressed that the game was quite fun and that they believed it would be enjoyable even outside a casual friends setting.

One noteworthy pattern in the feedback: women and players who had been less successful as traditional debaters said they strongly preferred this format. Men who had been highly successful debaters expressed finding it less exhilarating. One participant put it directly: "There are few things more ego-boosting than the feeling of total mind-domination that you get when you win a debate, and this cannot give you that."

One point everyone agreed on was that the format is much less anxiety-inducing than regular debate, while still providing a structure for meaningful conversation — unlike open real-life discussions, where people tend to fight over talking space.

One player suggested that the format might benefit from transitioning more wholeheartedly toward improv theatre — becoming a roleplaying game without any performance-evaluation component. Another countered that there is value in the sense that you are always progressing, at least a little, with every debate.

Annex G — Inside Out Debate Format: Third Design Iteration

The third design iteration is based on observations and participant feedback gathered during the second playtest (April 2026). The changes below supersede the corresponding elements in the second iteration (Annex B).

7.0.26 Role Renaming

Value Defenders are renamed Inner Voices. This name emerged organically during the second playtest, when players began referring to each other as "the other inner voices". It better reflects the roleplay-oriented nature of the format and the relationship between the Value Defender teams and the Subject.

7.0.27 S0 — Opening Subject Speech Instructions

The instructions for the opening Subject speech are revised to foreground the roleplay dimension:

> Hold a monologue as if you are the character, alone in a place of comfort, speaking to yourself about the dilemma. Express why this decision is truly difficult and how much getting it right matters to you. Explain why each value is relevant to this decision, and how you cannot simply disregard any of them. Do not lean toward any decision yet.

7.0.28 The Huddle

The Huddle is shortened from 10 minutes to **8 minutes**.

7.0.29 S2 — Final Subject Speech Instructions

The instructions for the final Subject speech are revised to include emotional closure:

> Synthesise all arguments and deliver a decision over a specific solution — a concrete course of action from those presented by the Inner Voices. Explain how everything in the debate contributed to this decision; leave nothing important out. Say why you feel this is the right decision, and how you now feel about making it.

7.0.30 Seating

A seating instruction is added: try to arrange chairs so that the Inner Voices and the Subject face each other. Inner Voices speak from where they sit, standing or seated. The Subject does the same. The Evaluator sits somewhere outside the main circle — present but out of sight, out of mind.

7.0.31 Specific Times

The following timing guidelines are provided:

- **Speaking times:** 5 minutes per speech.
- **Prep time:** 30 minutes for beginners or high-school debaters; 15 minutes for experienced adults.
- **Evaluator oral critique:** 10 minutes.
- **Evaluator-led debrief:** 15 minutes.

7.0.32 Rituals

The following rituals replace those described in the first design iteration (Annex A).

Rolling In.

1. **Evaluator opens** — The Evaluator says: *"You are here to decide together."*
2. **All respond** — Everyone answers: *"Yes, we are."* followed by shared clapping.

Calling an Inner Voice.

1. The Evaluator calls: *"Voice, speak for [Value]."*
2. The speaker **must begin their speech** with the words *"I will. . . "*

Rolling Out.

1. **Voices' thanks** — Each Inner Voice says: *"Thank you for listening to me."*
2. **Subject's thanks** — The Subject says to the Inner Voices: *"Thank you for speaking your truth."* The Subject then says to the Evaluator: *"Thank you for listening to me."*
3. **Bleed check** — Everyone states their real name and how they feel right now. The Evaluator then leads a brief debrief.

7.0.33 Commendation System

The commendation system is updated with a tier structure governing how commendations are distributed:

- Every debater should receive at least one **T1 (Earned)** commendation per speech. At higher levels of play, T1 commendations carry less competitive weight but remain a baseline acknowledgement of participation.
- The Evaluator has a **limited pool of T2 (Strong) and T3 (Exceptional)** commendations to offer per debate. These are awarded in private.

- Some commendations may be **exclusive to specific Evaluators**, reflecting their expertise or perspective.
- Some rounds or competitions may designate a **featured commendation** — a particular commendation given special significance in that context.

7.0.34 Evaluator Instructions

The Evaluator role is reframed toward active facilitation:

- You are the **facilitator** of the entire event. Your primary job is for everyone to feel safe and to play to grow.
- Feel free to **intervene** when it feels natural. Encourage players when you think it is necessary. Gently redirect when someone may be making others uncomfortable. Invite players out of their comfort zone when you believe it is in their best interest. Be human; establish a relationship of trust and growth with the others.
- After the debate ends, **first facilitate a brief debrief** stemming from the bleed check moment, then transition to the oral critique.
- Prepare **potential debrief questions** whilst others are preparing for the debate. Debrief questions should *not* focus (as the oral critique does) on skill growth, but rather on **meaningful emotional growth and acceptance of others' realities**. Explore how debaters would act in a similar scenario and what their own values are regarding the values explored in the debate. When in doubt, use these two anchor questions: *"How important are these values for you?"* and *"Were you in a similar scenario, what other values would influence you?"*
- Open the oral critique with a **narrative of the debate** from your outside perspective: what each team did and how it all unfolded.
- Engage directly with each team: ask what they **felt they did well** and what they found difficult. Share your view and add your own observations.
- Ask each team what they want to **do better next time**, and give concrete advice on how to get there.
- Award at least one **T1 (Earned)** commendation per speech to every debater. Use your limited pool of **T2 (Strong) and T3 (Exceptional)** commendations sparingly — these are awarded in private.

Annex H — Clues from Playtests

The following catalogue enumerates behavioral observations, reported experiences, and emergent patterns from both playtest sessions that constitute evidence relevant to the five evaluation fields used in the Results chapter. Each entry states what was observed, what it points toward, the theoretical mechanism connecting it to the relevant outcome, and an assessment of evidential strength (Strong / Moderate / Weak).

Sources: P1 = First playtest field notes (Jean Monet debate club, March 2026); P2 = Second playtest field notes (April 2026); D1/D2 = Post-session debrief responses after first/second playtest; T2 = Transcript of second playtest.

Field 1: Engagement, Appeal, and Long-Term Viability

1. **"Surprisingly liberating" / "a lot less anxiety"** (P1, D1)
   Points toward: Positive affective engagement; potential for voluntary repeated participation.
   Why: Emotional valence of first encounters strongly predicts willingness to re-engage. Absence of anxiety without absence of engagement is a difficult balance; its presence here suggests the transformational container is functioning as intended.
   Strength: Strong. Multiple independent reports across first playtest.

2. **Participants said they would play again and would "try to be more emotionally immersed" next time** (P1, D1)
   Points toward: Replayability; players perceive unexplored depth.
   Why: The desire to deepen engagement on replay indicates the format rewards mastery and exploration, a key condition for sustained community formation around a game.
   Strength: Moderate. Self-reported intention; actual re-engagement behaviour untested.

3. **Spontaneous adoption of "inner voices" terminology by players in second playtest** (P2, T2)
   Points toward: Imaginative investment; format's fictional premise genuinely inhabited.
   Why: Organic language generation signals that players were not merely following procedure but engaging imaginatively with the format's roleplay premise. This is a behavioral indicator rather than self-report, making it more credible.
   Strength: Strong. Unsolicited, behavioral, cross-confirmed by transcript.

4. **Women and less-successful-in-traditional-debate participants expressed strong preference for Inside Out** (P1, P2, D1, D2)
   Points toward: Broadened appeal; format reaching constituencies underserved by traditional debate.
   Why: Preference expressed independently by similar profiles across two separate sessions suggests a structural feature of the format rather than coincidence. Consistent with the design goal of redistributing who can succeed.
   Strength: Strong. Consistent across both playtests; theoretically coherent.

5. **One highly competitive debater found the format "anticlimactic" and missed "total mind-domination"** (P1, D1)
   Points toward: Format is not a direct replacement for traditional debate but serves a different audience.
   Why: This negative reaction from a specific profile (dominant competitive performer) is itself informative: it confirms the format is restructuring what is rewarded, as designed. The response is coherent with the format's intent.
   Strength: Moderate. Single report; theoretically coherent and useful for scoping the target audience.

Field 2: Productive Pressure Mechanisms

1. **"Architecting solutions very complex and interesting strategically"** (P1, D1)
   Points toward: Cognitive challenge maintained despite restructured format.
   Why: Players reporting the task as complex confirms the format does not simply reduce difficulty—it redirects it from rhetorical speed and coverage toward contextual reasoning and value argumentation.
   Strength: Moderate. Self-report of subjective difficulty; directionally strong.

2. **Subject player ran out of Huddle questions before 10 minutes elapsed** (P2)
   Points toward: Subject role is genuinely demanding; requires cognitive preparation and sustained presence.
   Why: Running out of facilitated questions is a design pressure point revealing that the Subject role needs scaffolding to sustain the Huddle productively. It simultaneously confirms that the role creates real intellectual demand.
   Strength: Moderate. Single observed instance; could reflect individual variation or a design gap requiring further testing.

3. **Commendations were challenging to assign without clear performance targets** (P2, D2)
   Points toward: Recognition system not yet calibrated for small, informal settings; needs an established circuit to become organic.
   Why: Difficulty assigning commendations is a weak negative clue suggesting the pressure/recognition mechanism is immature at this stage, but the evaluator's observation that memorized commendations become "more organic" points toward a viable long-term system.
   Strength: Weak (current scale); Moderate (projected at circuit scale).

Field 3: Growth Direction—Useful Skills and Perspectives

1. **All Value Defenders in second playtest immediately adopted roleplay stance: second-person address, eye contact with Subject, worldbuilding details** (P2, T2)
   Points toward: Spontaneous perspective-taking; format reliably elicits character inhabitation.

Why: Unsolicited roleplay behavior is a behavioral indicator of the imaginative engagement required for memetic and emancipatory bleed. Players spontaneously inhabiting their role suggests the format successfully creates the psychological conditions for transformation.
Strength: Strong. Behavioral, cross-confirmed by transcript, unsolicited.

2. **Subject's opening speech: player emotionally contextualized scenario, exposing "nuanced biases that bled from player to character"** (P2, T2)
Points toward: Bleed from player into character; format activating genuine value reflection.
Why: The Subject's first speech—describing the scenario in personal, emotional terms—created a vector for memetic bleed. Participants explicitly noted this as an institutionalization of existing debate practice ("playing for the judge") in a more transparent and intentional form.
Strength: Strong. Directly theoretically predicted; observed in transcript; verbally noted by participants.

3. **Participants articulated learning to "think about context of decisions," to be "more human and more honest about human nature"** (P1, D1)
Points toward: Cognitive and attitudinal growth aligned with format goals.
Why: Self-articulated growth in the precise domains the format targets (contextual reasoning, empathy, human complexity) is the most direct evidence available in the absence of pre/post measurement instruments.
Strength: Moderate. Self-report; retrospective; no pre-measure available for comparison.

4. **Participants accepted that "sometimes decisions are personal, not universal"** (P1, D1)
Points toward: Epistemic shift toward contextual rather than universalist reasoning.
Why: Traditional debate rewards universal claims. This reflection signals internalization of the format's procedural rhetoric: that value decisions are contextually embedded and legitimately vary by person and circumstance.
Strength: Moderate. Single session; self-report; aligns with theoretical prediction.

Field 4: Community Dynamics and Reduced Toxicity

1. **"Outright attacking others feels wrong, disrespectful, and unnecessary"—emergent norm in second playtest** (P2, D2)
Points toward: Spontaneous formation of collaborative rhetorical norms.
Why: This was not a stated rule but an emergent participant behavior: the format's procedural structure produced this norm without explicit instruction. This is a paradigmatic instance of procedural rhetoric reshaping community conduct.
Strength: Strong. Behavioral; emerged spontaneously; verbally articulated by multiple participants.

2. **"Much much less anxiety-inducing" than standard debate—consistent across**

both playtests (P1, P2, D1, D2)
Points toward: Transformational container functioning; psychological safety achieved.
Why: Anxiety reduction is a structural prerequisite for the emancipatory and memetic bleed the format aims to support. Consistent reporting across independent groups strengthens confidence in this finding.
Strength: Strong. Consistent across two independent sessions; multiple independent reports.

3. **Shifting focus and building on others' arguments felt "more natural and more persuasive" than rebuttal** (P2, D2)
Points toward: Rhetorical culture shift; collaborative argumentation becoming the default competitive strategy.
Why: When collaborative framing is perceived as more effective than adversarial framing, the competitive incentives of the format are aligned with its transformative goals. This is a coherent, self-reinforcing design outcome.
Strength: Moderate. Single playtest; self-report; theoretically coherent.

4. **Format still provided "structure for interesting conversation unlike open conversations that push toward fighting over talking space"** (P2, D2)
Points toward: Format occupies a productive middle ground—structured without being combative.
Why: This participant explicitly distinguishes Inside Out from both traditional debate (high anxiety, adversarial) and unstructured discussion (chaotic, dominated by loudest voices). This positions the format precisely where it was designed to sit.
Strength: Moderate. Single well-articulated report; high theoretical resonance.

Field 5: Epistemic Humility

1. **"Every team says valuable stuff and it is important more to see what is important to us"** (P1, D1)
Points toward: Epistemic humility: recognition that multiple competing perspectives hold genuine validity.
Why: This is the core attitudinal outcome targeted by the design. Explicit self-report of this attitude after a first encounter—without prompting—is notable evidence of the format's potential to shift perspective.
Strength: Moderate. Single playtest; self-report; directly on-target with design intent.

2. **Spontaneous consensus drift in second round of Value Defender speeches** (P2, T2)
Points toward: Players orienting toward value integration rather than competitive dominance.
Why: In traditional debate, second speeches intensify conflict. Here, players naturally moved toward synthesis without instruction. This procedural outcome is consistent with the format's design and constitutes a behavioral rather than self-reported indicator.
Strength: Strong. Behavioral; transcript-confirmed; emergent; theoretically predicted.

3. **Unplanned bleed event: participant shared during a break that the debate scenario "hit uncannily close to home"—a family member had asked them that day to provide false testimony** (P2)
   Points toward: Format successfully activating personal value reflection and real-world epistemic engagement.
   Why: Unplanned bleed—where a fictional scenario activates genuine personal stakes—is the strongest available indicator that the transformational container is functioning. The fact that this was shared spontaneously and privately (not as a performance for the researcher) increases its credibility substantially.
   Strength: Strong. Behavioral; spontaneous; private; paradigmatic instance of transformative bleed.

4. **Subject player noted conscious transition from roleplay mindframe (S0 speech) to evaluative mindframe (S2 speech) as debate progressed** (P2, T2)
   Points toward: Format produces genuine movement between epistemic stances within a single round.
   Why: The arc from emotionally inhabited Subject opening to reflective evaluative closing demonstrates the format's capacity to move participants through different modes of reasoning—experiential, empathic, then analytical—in a single structured encounter.
   Strength: Moderate. Single participant report; theoretically significant; coherent with format design.

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